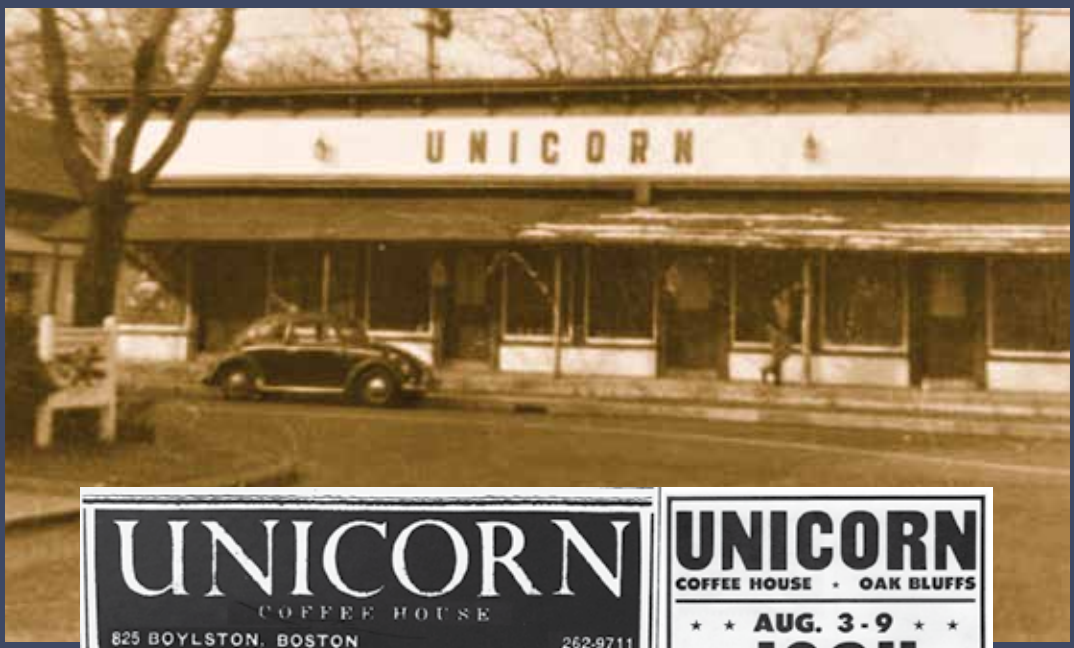
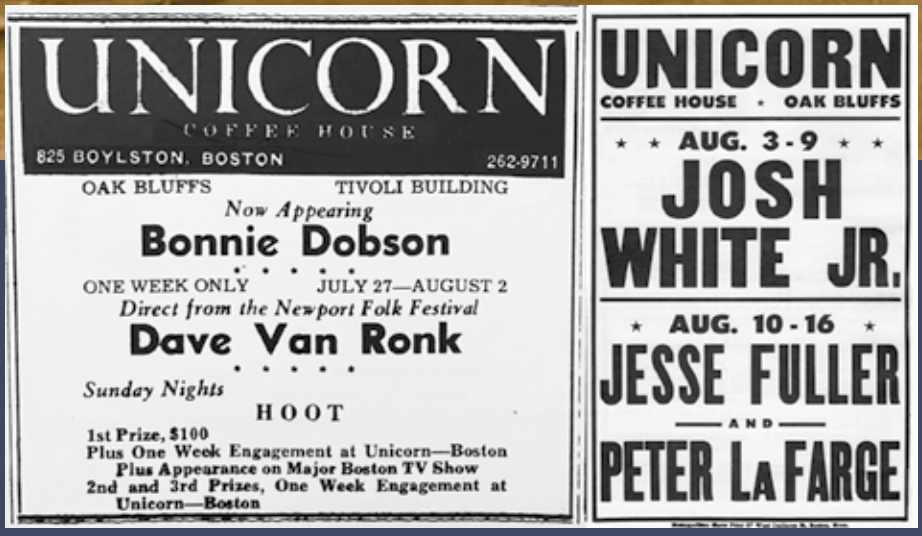
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Martha's Vineyard Museum's Journal of Island History
NOVEMBER 2023
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The Unicorn Coffee House





Nineveh and the Vineyard
Norman Bridwell

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New Horizons

Publication of this journal began more than sixty years ago, in August 1959. Over that time, it has had seven editors. Beginning with the next issue, it will have a new one: Alex Dueben. The current issue will be my last. I am not leaving the Island, the Museum, or the pages of the *Quarterly*. It is, however, time for me to leave the editorial chair.

When I accepted the editorship, it was in addition to a part-time job overseeing the Museum's library and archives. That job is now full-time, and its scope has steadily expanded; it is no longer possible for one person to do both. The *Quarterly* will be the new editor's sole MVM responsibility. They will have the freedom to focus on it and the chance to once again bring its publication schedule into alignment with the calendar.

I have tried, over the last nine years, to publish articles that highlight ways in which the Vineyard is enmeshed with the wider world. This issue serves that goal. It includes Doug Thompson's history of the Unicorn Coffee House, which drew nationally known musicians to Oak Bluffs for two magical summers in the mid-1960s; Aidan Charron and Jim Richardson's exploration of why archaeological discoveries in the nineteenth-century Middle East fascinated a middle-aged teacher from Vineyard Haven; and Linsey Lee's conversations with Norman Bridwell, creator of Clifford the Big Red Dog. My own brief look at Dionis Coffin Riggs' attempt to pitch her biographical novel *From Off Island* (1940) to Hollywood rounds out the issue.

The new editor will, like every editor before them, have their own vision for the journal. Yet, the *Quarterly* will continue to bring forward untold Island stories, and to consider familiar ones from fresh perspectives. I look forward, like you, to discovering them—in print and online—four times a year.

— A. Bowdoin Van Riper, editor

MARTHA'S VINEYARD MUSEUM
QUARTERLY

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— As of November 2023 —

The Unicorn Coffee House

by W. Douglas Thompson

Night life in Boston and Cambridge was teeming with folk music. It was 1962, and Vineyard native Thomas J. DeMont, Jr. was in the thick of it all.[1] DeMont's passion for folk music had developed at campfires on the Menemsha Beach and at house parties around the Island. He played the trumpet in local school bands and taught himself to play the guitar. After graduating from the Oak Bluffs High School in 1959, DeMont moved to Boston, where he studied art education at the Massachusetts College of Art. In Boston he became friends with master guitarist and blues vocalist Geoff Muldaur, himself a seasonal resident of the Vineyard and at the time a student at Boston University. DeMont and Muldaur got together frequently to share songs and to hone their musical skills. They performed together publicly at The Turk's Head, an intimate coffee house on Charles Street.

Among DeMont's favorite haunts at the time was the Unicorn Coffee House on Boylston Street. He was one of those hardcore frequent customers who would perhaps volunteer to help out in minor ways around the club but who would over time become a regular fixture who could get in for free, receive complimentary food and beverages, and enjoy opportunities to socialize backstage with the performers.

The owner of the Unicorn was George Papadopoulo, a Greek Cypriot

1 This article is based in part on correspondence and/or interviews with the following individuals between 1994 and 2023: Povy La Farge Bigbee, Nancy Crossley Blank, Craig Buddington, Christine Harmon (now Christine Cameron), Allan Crossley, Katie deBettencourt, Thomas J. DeMont Jr., Jessie Dill Jakobs, Christine Lavin, Alex Lukeman, Robert Mazetta, Day Merrill, Virginia De Rieux Papadopoulo, Cheryl Roedel Sudderth, Elijah Wald, and Carol Metcalfe Wyeth. Additional assistance was provided by Sara Crafts, Tom Fisher, Marty Nadler, and Rizwan Malik. The author (w.douglas.thompson@gmail.com) welcomes correspondence from anyone interested in sharing their memories of the Unicorn.

W. Douglas Thompson was born on the Vineyard and currently divides his time between Portland, Maine, and his seasonal Campground cottage on Trinity Park in Oak Bluffs.



Thomas J. DeMont, Jr., circa 1959.

who immigrated from Alexandria, Egypt. Papadopoulo had arrived in the United States in 1953 at the age of 25, when he accompanied an Egyptian Boy Scout troop to the International Boy Scout Jamboree, which was being held in Southern California that year. He had originally planned on returning to Egypt at the end of the Jamboree and to work at the American-style grocery store owned by his parents. However, once in the U.S., Papadopoulo decided to remain and further his education. After studies at Pasadena City College and earning a degree in food technology at Oregon State University, he moved east and settled in Boston, where he landed a job as director of the Boston International Film Festival. Papadopoulo was impressed with the business opportunities created by the burgeoning folk music scene in Boston and Cambridge, and he soon opened the Unicorn Coffee House at 825 Boylston Street. In addition to running his highly successful coffee house, Papadopoulo began producing folk music concerts under the Unicorn banner at larger venues such as Symphony Hall and Jordan Hall.

A Meeting in Edgartown

In the summer of 1963, Papadopoulo also had a small business interest on Martha's Vineyard. John Chirgwin, son of the owners of the Daggett House in Edgartown, was operating a gift shop (later known as The Golden Door), and he had agreed to sell on consignment some Egyptian jewelry on behalf of Papadopoulo. That summer, Chirgwin's cousin, Patricia Hoyt of California, had come east to work at the Harborside Inn, and she had invited her best friend Virginia De Rieux to join her on the Vineyard for a week late in June.

One day during her visit, De Rieux agreed to tend Chirgwin's shop so he could go out sailing. While De Rieux was in charge, Papadopoulo walked into the shop, sat down, and began reading the newspaper, totally ignoring the young woman at the counter. De Rieux was "rather nonplussed and a little annoyed" by the behavior of such a presumptuous customer.[2] Papadopoulo did eventually explain his friendship with Chirgwin and the proprietor's consignment of jewelry for him. De Rieux soon warmed up to the stranger, and within months of that first

2 Virginia De Rieux Papadopoulo, correspondence, April 4, 2022..



George Papadopoulo aboard the Chirgwin family's Rhodes 19 sailboat, Bête Noire, in Edgartown Harbor, 1963.

meeting, she had moved from California to Cambridge and had married Papadopoulo. She began working closely with him on his Boston-based businesses.

A New Partnership

DeMont found Papadopoulo to be charming and intelligent, and in the spring of 1964 the two formed a partnership to open a branch of the Unicorn on Martha's Vineyard. Expansion had already been on Papadopoulo's mind; he was planning to establish a satellite Unicorn in Stowe, Vermont, the following winter.[3] Furthermore, Papadopoulo already knew something of what was happening musically on the Vineyard. While on the Vineyard in July of 1963 he had visited the newly opened Moon-Cusser Coffee House on Circuit Avenue in Oak Bluffs. David Lyman, the manager of that establishment during its first year, had previously worked for Papadopoulo at the Boston Unicorn.

Papadopoulo's visit to the Moon-Cusser might well have sparked his competitive impulses. He had competed effectively with the numerous folk venues springing up in Boston and Cambridge, and he likely would have felt confident about taking on just a single rival establishment on the Vineyard. Thus, in advance of the 1964 summer season, it was full speed ahead with the Vineyard project. The new partners soon found suitable space above the showroom of Manter Motors at Five Corners in Vineyard Haven.



George Papadopoulo with his wife Virginia, whom he met in Edgartown, 1964.

3 Edie Blake, "Coffee Houses Plus: Genre Proliferates on the Vineyard This Summer," *Vineyard Gazette*, July 24, 1964, 3-A.



Original location of the Unicorn Coffee House above Manter Auto Sales at Five Corners in Vineyard Haven.

A Former Street Musician

The first professional performer booked into their hastily set up venue in the summer of 1964 was the legendary blind blues and gospel singer Reverend Gary Davis (1896-1972). As Stambler and Landon have noted, Davis was "a towering figure in blues and gospel history," a man who "during his many years of performing served as an inspiration and a musical model for countless younger artists."[4] While living in the Carolinas in the 1930s, Davis had been a major participant in the Piedmont blues scene, and there he also became an ordained Baptist minister. In the 1940s Davis had moved to New York City, where he earned his living as a Harlem street musician and sidewalk preacher.[5] Davis had first come to the attention of nationally prominent folk and blues musicians when he performed at a memorial concert for Huddy Ledbetter ("Leadbelly") in 1950.[6] As the public's interest in folk music grew in the late 1950s, Davis had been invited to perform at the inaugural year of the Newport Folk Festival in 1959.[7]

4 Irwin Stambler and Grelun Landon, *The Encyclopedia of Folk, Country, & Western Music*, Saint Martin's Press, 1984, 168.

5 Ian Zack, *Say No to the Devil: The Life and Musical Genius of Rev. Gary Davis*, University of Chicago Press, 2015.

6 Zack, *Say No to the Devil*, 1-5.

7 Zack, *Say No to the Devil*, 113.

In advance of Davis' first appearance in Boston at Café Yana in 1962, the *Broadside of Boston* had heralded him as "one of the finest guitarists and most exciting performers active today" and noted that "his gospel and spiritual songs are the fire and earth of life."[8] Many aspiring young performers flocked to Davis to study guitar with him. Davis charged five dollars per lesson, many of which lasted for several hours and might include dinner prepared by Davis' wife. Among his students who went on to become major figures in the folk music boom and the folk-rock era that followed were Roy Book Binder, David Bromberg, Ian Buchanan, Ry Cooder, Stefan Grossman, Janis Ian, Steve Katz (co-founder of Blood, Sweat, and Tears), and Bob Weir.[9]

Biographer Ian Zack noted that "While young people in the United States paid their respects to American roots music, their European counterparts were enthralled by it." Just weeks prior to his appearance on the Vineyard, Davis had traveled to England to participate in a multi-city series of concerts called the American Blues and Gospel Caravan, which also included Muddy Waters, Sonny Terry, Brownie McGhee, and others. For Davis, the Caravan gave him "his first taste of the star treatment accorded to the likes of Joan Baez and Bob Dylan back home, with adoring crowds and prominent press coverage in every city."[10]

Writing in *Jazz Monthly* about one of the stops on the Caravan tour, Simon A. Napier remarked: "Gary Davis on stage can produce the most wonderful country gospel music any concert stage is ever likely to see. His moving and beautiful rendering of 'Pure Religion' was one of the most wonderful things I have ever witnessed."[11]

In the years following his appearance at the Vineyard Unicorn in 1964, Davis continued performing and recording, but the audiences for solo acts featuring traditional music were shrinking rapidly in the U.S. as rock bands proliferated. British interest in American roots music did nevertheless remain quite high all through the 1960s. In the summer of 1971, just months before his death, Davis returned to England for sixteen highly successful appearances in two and a half weeks.[12] In *Blues Unlimited*, David Harrison described Davis, then 75 years old, as "frail and looking extremely old," but the Reverend apparently dug deep and still managed to give "a stunning show."[13]

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8 *Broadside of Boston,* vol. 1, no. 19 (November 16, 1962), 7.
9 Zack, *Say No to the Devil*.
10 Zack, *Say No to the Devil*, 186-7.
11 Simon A. Napier, "The Folk Blues and Gospel Caravan," *Jazz Monthly*, July 1964, 6-7.
12 Zack, *Say No to the Devil*, 250.
13 David Harrison, *Blues Unlimited*, no. 85 (October 1971), 20.

A Scare for Young DeMont

For the weekend of Davis' engagement at the Unicorn, as for most weekends, George Papadopoulo was off-Island tending to the Boston Unicorn, leaving Thomas DeMont to manage things on the Vineyard. That weekend turned out to be a particularly dramatic one. DeMont has described the final evening of Davis' engagement as follows:

> Davis loved his red wine. When we got him, we were given this warning more or less—this admonition—that we were to keep all alcoholic beverages away from Gary Davis before he went on stage. In other words, try to keep him sober at all costs. Don't let a lot of people go backstage before the performance to visit him because the temptation was that he would ask someone to get him liquor.
>
> So we tried desperately to do this.
>
> Of course, somebody got backstage with a gallon of red wine, and as I can recall—to my horrors—going back there we had I think about ten minutes to get him onstage before lights were going up. He had this black sport coat on, a really rumbled pretty old black sport coat and a white shirt. Down the white shirt, of course, were these 'wonderful' wine-colored stains.
>
> And I said, 'Uh-oh!' Here I am just a young kid and here is this old guy, this grizzly old guy—blind as a bat, of course—now with wine stains on his shirt. Finally, with much persuading, we did get him to go up on stage.
>
> He kept asking me prior to going up on stage where George was, … and he wanted to know whether he was going to get his money before he performed or after he performed. So I said, 'Listen, George will be back tomorrow with the money for you.'
>
> So Gary Davis gets on stage, and he plays a few songs. And of course his famous song was 'Cocaine Blues.' So, he starts singing 'Cocaine Blues,' and he could keep it going for, oh, anywhere from 15 minutes to 45 minutes, just making up new verses as he went along. About halfway through, about 10 minutes into 'Cocaine Blues' he stopped playing. He stands up and he pulls a gun out of his jacket!
>
> Of course, I'm watching. I see this gun come out, so, God! Myself and a couple of other guys go up to the stage. The audience didn't really know what was going on, so we had to hustle him off stage. Well, here he is. He pokes this gun in my face. He wants his money instantly—right on the spot. And he's going to shoot somebody—namely me.

In his memoir, Dave van Ronk noted that Davis "used to carry this big .38 that he called 'Miss Ready.' He would pull out this gun and show it to me, and one time, diffidently as I could, I said, 'You know, Gary, you *are* blind. Don't you think maybe it's not such a good idea…' He said, 'If I can hear it, I can shoot it.'"[14] Fortunately, Davis did not fire his "Miss Ready"

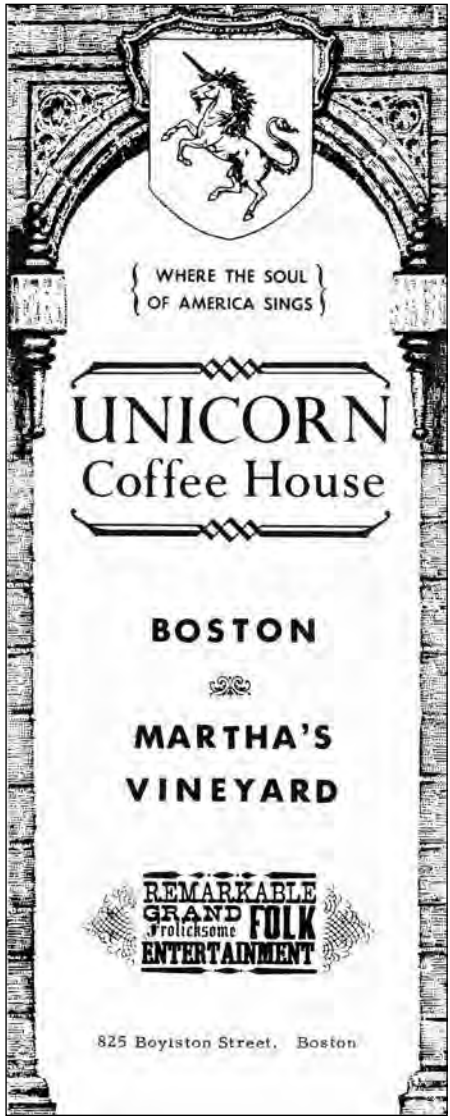
14 Dave Van Ronk with Elijah Wald, *The Mayor of MacDougal Street: A Memoir* (Da Capo Press, 2005), 138.

that night at the Vineyard Unicorn. DeMont ultimately managed to convince him to wait until the next morning, when Papadopoulo did in fact arrive with payment for Davis.

A Rapid Change of Venue

A second episode involving demands for money followed closely on the heals of the tense evening with Gary Davis at the Vineyard Unicorn. Quite possibly, alcohol was again a factor.

At the time, the man responsible for the building and the car dealership down on the first floor below the Unicorn was Sterling Magee, nephew of William G. Manter's widow. One evening with a full house awaiting the start of the entertainment, Magee barged in, heatedly in pursuit of rent money. He started ranting, and he shouted so menacingly that many members of the audience fled the establishment. DeMont and Papadopoulo had had enough; they saw no option but to relocate the Unicorn.



Advertisement in the *Broadside of Boston,* July 22, 1964.

New rental space for the Unicorn was quickly secured in an aging Oak Bluffs landmark, the Tivoli Building. The Tivoli (I-LOV-IT spelled backwards) had been built in 1907, and in its early glory days its second-story dancehall attracted leading dance bands and huge crowds. By the 1950s, however, the bands and the dancers were gone. The Oak Bluffs postmaster, Alfred E. Holmes, had turned the dancehall into a roller-skating rink, but that noisy enterprise precipitated a lawsuit brought by Frank Yan Ng, who ran the restaurant below.[15] In the period 1958-1961 the Tivoli offered little else other than weekly wrestling matches.

Miraculously, in 1962, music and dancing had returned to the Tivoli.

15 Arthur R. Railton, "The Story of Martha's Vineyard: How We Got To Where We Are (Chapter Ten)", *Dukes County Intelligencer,* August 2004, 24.



The Tivoli in its prime.

Responsible for this brief renaissance were Allen Hovey and Hamilton Benz, who put together a musical group called The Moonrakers.[16] The group was directed by pianist David Borden and included Larry Benz on trombone, Ronald Crotti on trumpet, Arthur Silva on bass, Hovey himself on drums and vibes, and vocalist Merrily Benz.[17] The Moonrakers played from 8:00 to midnight on Thursday, Friday, and Saturday nights.[18] In 1963 a new creative arts center for children had also been located at the Tivoli.[19]

In July of 1964, the entire move of the Unicorn from Vineyard Haven to the Tivoli Building took place within just one bustling 24-hour period. Thanks in large part to the efforts of a couple of dozen enthusiastic young volunteers, not a single night's show had to be canceled on account of the move.

The space that the owners of the Unicorn secured in the Tivoli was on the first floor and likely was where Ng had operated his restaurant. The new Unicorn had a seating capacity of 200. A victualer's license was approved by the Oak Bluffs selectmen on July 23. The owners had hired five servers, with two additional servers brought in on the weekends. Like the original Unicorn in Boston, the Vineyard branch had no liquor license. The specialty drink of the house was Folk Singer's Delight, a drink consisting of lemonade, ginger, and honey. The owners bragged to the *Vineyard*

16 "Moonraker" is a synonym for moonsail, a light square sail set above a skysail and carried by some clipper ships in light winds. In Britain the term is also a synonym for simpleton. Choice of name for the group may also have been influenced by the 1955 novel *Moonraker*, which was the third in Ian Fleming's James Bond series.

17 "Tivoli Is Reborn," *Vineyard Gazette*, July 10, 1962, 3.

18 *Vineyard Gazette*, July 6, 1962, 8.

19 *Vineyard Gazette*, July 26, 1963, 7.



Headlining acts at the Unicorn in 1964: Reverend Gary Davis, Bonnie Dobson, Dave Van Ronk, Josh White Jr., Jesse Fuller, Peter La Farge, The Kentucky Colonels (Billy Ray Latham, Roland White, Roger Bush, and Clarence White), Dayle Stanley, and The New Prince Spaghetti Minstrels (Paul Toner, Fred Dill, George Hallisey, Robert Mazetta, Katie deBettencourt, Carol Metcalfe, and John Neyes).

Gazette about their espresso machine "in which the coffee is cooked under pressure, as it is in Italy." In addition to a variety of coffees and teas and hot chocolate flavored with mint or caramel, mysterious cold drinks with names like Unicorn's Blood and Witch's Brew were served.[20] Pastries were not made on-Island but were brought down from Boston by Papadopoulo on his weekly commute.

Selection of talent for the Vineyard Unicorn was shared by Papadopoulo and DeMont, although Papadopoulo conducted the actual negotiations with the performers or their agents. In addition to Rev. Gary Davis, talent brought in for the 1964 season included Bonnie Dobson,

20 Edie Blake, "Coffee Houses Plus: Genre Proliferates on the Vineyard This Summer," *Vineyard Gazette*, July 24, 1964, 3-A.

Dave Van Ronk, Josh White Jr., Jesse Fuller, Peter La Farge, The Kentucky Colonels, Dayle Stanley, and a seven-person ensemble called the New Prince Spaghetti Minstrels.[21]

A Popular Canadian Performer

Bonnie Dobson was born in Toronto in 1940 and began performing publicly in Canada as a college student. In 1960 she branched out to touring in the western and mid-western United States. When Dobson first performed in New York City in 1962 at Gerde's Folk City, Robert Shelton of the *New York Times* praised "her true-pitched singing in a firm, sweet soprano" and "her ingratiating honesty and warmth on stage." Shelton also commented that "her songbag includes French-Canadian airs, but leans mostly on traditional Anglo-American songs of love, passion and remorse, of maids deceived and rogues unpunished."[22]

The entertainment magazine *Variety* noted that Dobson had "a sweet pure voice and brings a highly personalized approach to her work that denotes deep conviction. Her repertoire provides a solid showcase for her ability as she includes songs of substance from Canada, the U.S., England, Scotland, Ireland, France, Yugoslavia, and Czechoslovakia. All are ably self-accompanied on guitar, and sung with sincerity, delicacy, and humor."[23]

In the months following her first performance in New York, Dobson had played at Club 47 in Cambridge, the Ballad & Banjo in Hyannis, and the Boston Unicorn. Along with Bob Gibson, the Limelighters, and Bud & Travis, she had starred on the premiere episode of the American Broadcasting Company's weekly television program *Hootenanny*. It aired on April 6, 1963. Her appearance at the Vineyard Unicorn in 1964 was her second on the Island; in the summer of 1963 she had shared the bill with singer Don Paulin at the Moon-Cusser Coffee House on Circuit Avenue.

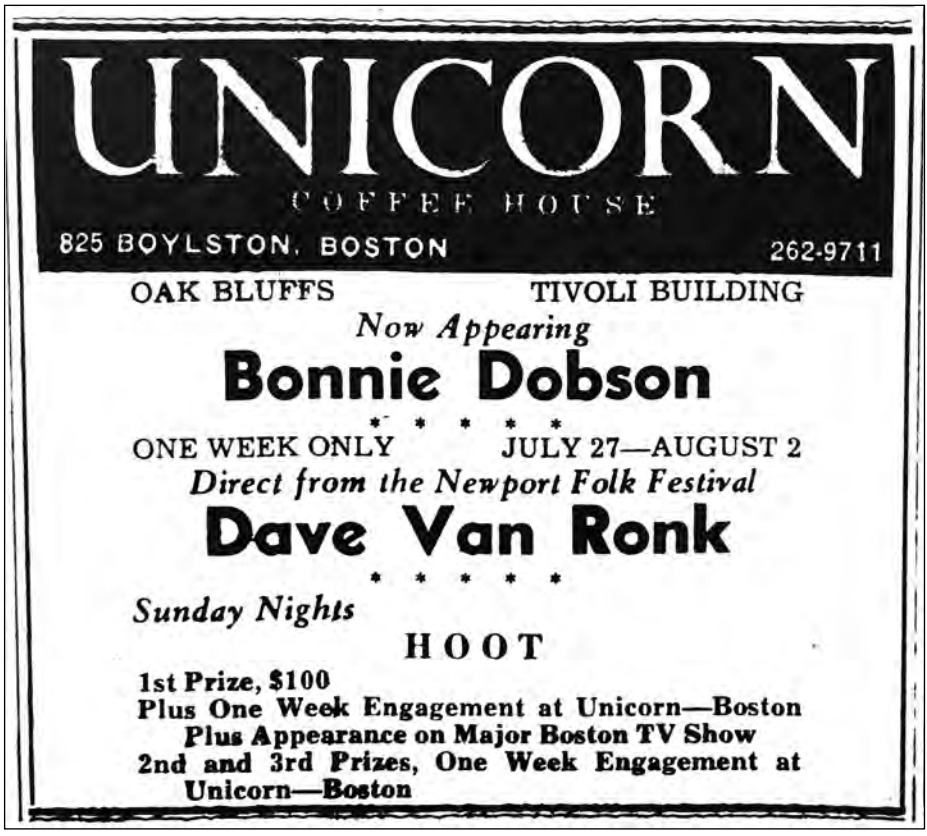
In addition to traditional folk material, Dobson performed her own compositions. Her most well-known song, "Morning Dew," was inspired by Nevil Shute's 1957 post-apocalyptic novel *On the Beach* and was published on the cover of the seventh issue of the long-running New York *Broadside* in June of 1962.[24] "Morning Dew" was later recorded by the Grateful Dead on their first album, and also by the Jeff Beck Group (with Rod Stewart on vo-

21 In July of 1964 a poster was printed listing the final three acts for the season as Mississippi John Hurt, Tripjacks, and Jim Kweskin & The Jug Band. However, the schedule was later revised and none of these three acts performed at the Vineyard Unicorn in either 1964 or 1965.

22 Robert Shelton, *New York Times*, February 28, 1962.

23 *Variety*, April 25, 1962, 53.

24 This published version of the song inexplicably replaced "dew" with "sun". Nevertheless, the song was in good company; on the cover of its previous issue in late May the New York *Broadside* had published "Blowin' in the Wind" by Bob Dylan.



Advertisement in the Vineyard Gazette, July 24, 1964.

cals), Duane and Gregg Allman, Robert Plant, and others. Throughout the 1960s Dobson performed and recorded extensively. She moved to England in 1969, where she continued to put out records and made limited public appearances. For many years she was an administrator at the Birkbeck College of the University of London. In 2018 Dobson was inducted into the Canadian Songwriters Hall of Fame for "Morning Dew."

A Greenwich Village Luminary

Dave Van Ronk's powerful gravelly voice and his virtuoso fingerpicking, as well as his imposing physical presence and sharp wit, earned him the status of revered head of the Greenwich Village folk music scene in the 1950s and 1960s. Van Ronk embraced a wide range of musical traditions, including blues, jazz, gospel, jug band music, ragtime, and rock.

Bob Dylan has written that, when he was just starting out, Van Ronk "was the one performer I burned to learn particulars from."[25] Dylan ob-

25 Bob Dylan, *Chronicles, Volume 1* (Simon & Schuster, 2004), 261.

served that "Van Ronk could howl and whisper, turn the blues into ballads and ballads into blues"[26] and that Van Ronk's voice "was like rusted shrapnel and he could get a lot of subtle ramifications out of it—delicate, gentle, rough, explosive, sometimes all within the same song. He could conjure up anything—expressions of terror, expressions of despair. He also was an expert guitar player."[27]

Although most associated with Greenwich Village, where he lived for almost his entire professional life, Van Ronk performed frequently in Boston and Cambridge at the Unicorn, Café Yana, and Club 47. In a 1964 poll taken among the readership of the *Broadside of Boston*, Van Ronk won in the category of Favorite Visiting Performer, beating out such notable folk singers and players as Bob Dylan himself, Jean Redpath, Phil Ochs, Jose Feliciano, Ramblin' Jack Elliott, and Doc Watson.[28]

Thirty years after his 1964 appearance at the Vineyard Unicorn, Van Ronk returned to the Island to participate in Christine Lavin's Second Annual Singer/Songwriter Retreat, which was headquartered at 2 Nashawena Park in Oak Bluffs and which held its performances at the Wintertide Coffee House in Vineyard Haven, downstairs in the very building where the Unicorn had begun its first year of operation. The recordings emanating from that retreat featured Van Ronk singing his signature version of "Green, Green Rocky Road" (by Len Chandler and poet Bob Kaufman), as well as him teaming up with Tom Paxton to pay musical tribute to the memory of blues performer Mississippi John Hurt, who had been an important influence on both men.[29]

Van Ronk remained active on the folk club and concert circuit up until just a few weeks before his death in 2002.

A Second-Generation Troubadour

Josh White Jr., whose godmother was none other than Eleanor Roosevelt, started singing in public with his famous father in 1944 at the age of four. Five years later, father and son acted together in a Broadway play entitled *How Long till Summer.* Although the review of the play in the *New York Post* bore the headline "A Well-Intentioned Catastrophe," it described Josh White Jr. as "charming" and "talented." The *New Yorker* found his performance to be "remarkably touching," while the *Daily News* characterized the young actor as the play's "best feature … a grand little boy with a lot of drive and talent." White won a special Tony Award as the

26 Bob Dylan, *Chronicles*, 15.

27 Dylan, *Chronicles*, 262.

28 *Broadside of Boston,* vol. 3, no. 6 (May 13, 1964).

29 The recorded collection of live performances from that retreat was released in 1994 and was entitled *Follow That Road*. The recordings from Lavin's first annual retreat were released in 1993 as *Big Times in a Small Town: The Vineyard Tapes.*

year's best child actor, and then in 1951 he returned to Broadway in a play starring Dorothy Gish.[30]

Despite his remarkable early success as an actor, young White continued singing publicly with his father and other family members, and in 1961 he was persuaded to go out on the road as a solo musical act. In that year, *New York Times* columnist Robert Shelton commented that White has "a pleasant-textured refined tenor and a pocketful of self-assurance" but that he "has not yet sufficiently assimilated the many styles of his father and others he has studied to have developed an identifiable performing personality."[31] As much as he paid homage to his father in all of his solo performances, White obviously sought to establish himself as a talent in his own right. Unfortunately, promotors sometimes worked at cross-purposes. White described one aspect of the problem to his father's biographer as follows:



Poster announcing three acts at the Unicorn in 1964, with the "JR." in "JOSH WHITE JR." printed in a contract-compliant manner.

> When I became a solo performer, people would capitalize off the fact that I was his son. It might happen, if it was a joint my old man had not played because they couldn't afford him, but they could afford me, there would be big letters outside. 'JOSH WHITE,' and then a tiny 'jr.' Which was not fair to the people and was not fair to me. So we had to put in my contract that the 'J' in 'Jr.' was to be 100 percent type and the 'r' was to be no less than 60 percent, so they could not do that.[32]

By the time that Josh White Jr. performed on the Vineyard in 1964, he had indeed developed his own performing personality and had a repertoire that overlapped with that of his father in just a few irresistible key instances. He had recently gained national exposure appearing on ABC television's popular *Hootenanny* show.

One thing that the younger White certainly did share with his father was a commitment to political activism. A few weeks after his appearance on the Vineyard, White performed with his father, Peter La Farge, and

30 Elijah Wald, *Josh White: Society Blues* (University of Massachusetts Press, 2000), 169-170.

31 Robert Shelton, *New York Times*, September 21, 1961.

32 Wald, *Josh White*, 290.

Dayle Stanley at the Baltimore Civic Center for a gala where President Lyndon Johnson was the featured speaker.[33]

Over the early 60 years since his gig at the Unicorn, White has continued to perform, often in support of worthy ideals. In August of 2018, for example, he performed at the Franklin D. Roosevelt Presidential Library in Hyde Park, New York, to honor the 70th anniversary year of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights.[34]

A One-Man Band

Jesse Fuller was born in Jonesboro, Georgia in 1896. He never knew his father and, in order to find work for herself, his mother left him with a family that treated him badly. Consequently, Fuller learned to fend for himself at an early age. By age nine he had established his own business grazing cows. As a teenager he worked in a barrel factory, a broom factory, rock quarry, and a sawmill. As an adult, on his way from Georgia to California via Cincinnati, Fuller worked for a streetcar company and for the Hagenbeck-Wallace Circus. Once in Los Angeles, he shined shoes, washed cars, sold wooden snakes that he carved, and eventually operated a hot dog stand on a Hollywood movie lot. Thanks to contacts he made at that location, Fuller was hired as an extra on several films, including the 1924 classic *The Thief of Bagdad*. In 1929 Fuller moved to Oakland, where he worked on the railway and as a welder.[35]

Fuller had begun developing his musical skills playing blues guitar at age 10, but he did not seriously consider earning his living as a musician and songwriter until the early 1950s. He soon discovered that it was difficult to find skilled and dependable musicians to travel with him, so he adopted the nickname "Lone Cat" and went about equipping himself as a one-man band. Fuller played twelve-string guitar, held a harmonica and a kazoo in a rack around his neck, used his left foot to operate a high-hat cymbal, and tapped out bass notes with his right foot on an instrument of his own invention, which he called a fotdella. Fuller's fotdella had an upright box shaped like the top of a bass fiddle. Across the box were stretched five or six strings, each of which Fuller operated by a treadle that activated a felt-tipped piano hammer.[36]

Robert Shelton of the *New York Times* had reviewed Fuller's first appearance in New York as follows: "The sound of the one-man band is quietly rocking, insistently rhythmic and infectious. Mr. Fuller's lyrics are

33 *The Evening Sun* (Baltimore), October 16, 1964, 30.

34 *Poughkeepsie Journal*, August 3, 2018, E12.

35 Elijah Wald, "Jesse Fuller: San Francisco Bay Blues," *Acoustic Guitar*, no. 55 (July 1997); *Broadside of Boston,* vol. 3, no. 4 (April 1, 1964); *Broadside of Boston,* vol. 5, no. 7 (May 24, 1966).

36 Wald, "Jesse Fuller"; Van Ronk, 2, 115-116.

often swallowed or smeared, in the old country blues fashion. For those who like this genre, he is hard to resist."[37]

Fuller had a profound effect on the music of the 1960s and far beyond. His song "You're No Good" was the first song on Bob Dylan's debut album. The Grateful Dead included Fuller's "Beat It On Down The Line" on their debut album and performed the song live at hundreds of concerts. Fuller's most well-known composition "San Francisco Bay Blues," written in 1954, was performed not only by many folk performers, such as Ramblin' Jack Elliott and Peter, Paul & Mary, but also by a host of other popular singers that includes Paul McCartney, Eric Clapton, Janis Joplin, Richie Havens, and Eva Cassidy.

Elijah Wald has summed up Fuller's career in this way: "Unlike most of the older bluesmen who appeared on the folk circuit in the 1960s, Fuller was at home in the present, in tune with the contemporary scene and fully in charge of his life, music, and business. He knew what he was doing, and knew he was good at it, and it did not surprise him when the young, white folksingers started coming around to admire and learn from him. And learn they did."[38]

A Voice in Support of Native Americans

Peter La Farge arrived on the Vineyard shortly after a two-week engagement at the Boston Unicorn. He was 34 years old, and at that point in his brief career, he had already put out four record albums under the Folkways and Columbia labels. One of those albums consisted of cowboy songs and the others dealt primarily with Native American themes. La Farge was the son of Oliver La Farge, a writer and anthropologist who specialized in Native American culture.[39] The younger La Farge, like his father, was a passionate champion of the rights of Native Americans, and his music eloquently highlighted the disgraceful treatment that they endured. La Farge also claimed that he himself was of Native American descent. However, recent research has not confirmed such ancestry.[40]

La Farge, who was born in 1931, had been raised on a ranch in Fountain, Colorado, and at various points he had been a rodeo rider and boxer. At age 18 he joined the Navy and served aboard the USS *Boxer* aircraft car-

37 Robert Shelton, "One-Man Band From West Coast: Jesse Fuller Plays a Fotdella, et al., at Gerde's Folk City," *New York Times*, Nov. 2, 1962, 25.

38 Wald, "Jesse Fuller."

39 The elder La Farge won the Pulitzer Prize for his novel *Laughing Boy*, published in 1929.

40 G. T. Cranston, "The View from Swamptown: Peter La Farge Left Behind a Legacy of Native American Advocacy," *The Independent* (North Kingstown, and South Kingstown, Rhode Island), August 4, 2019. Extensive genealogical research by the author has found no evidence for La Farge having had Native American ancestry. No family member other than Peter La Farge himself seems to have claimed such ancestry.

rier in the Korean War. After briefly considering a career in acting, La Farge had settled in New York City and began performing folk songs and his original compositions in the small clubs of Greenwich Village. Instrumental in his development as a songwriter was Cisco Houston. La Farge once said: "Cisco worked hours with me teaching me not only music and how to use words, but giving me a whole philosophy of life."[41]

La Farge's best-known song, "The Ballad of Ira Hayes," told the tragic story of a Pima Indian who was one of the six Marines in the iconic Joe Rosenthal photograph of the raising of the American flag over Iwo Jima in 1945. The song was covered by many artists, most notably Johnny Cash, who had a hit record with it. Cash included several of La Farge's songs on his album entitled *Bitter Tears*.

In its review of La Farge's album *As Long as the Grass Shall Grow*, the magazine *High Fidelity* announced that "The American Indian has finally found a champion, a balladeer whose songs chronicle the long, unequal struggle against men and laws that have dispossessed—and continue to dispossess—the tribes of the ancestral lands." The review went on to note that the record's title song "caustically indicts a dam recently built in New York State, one that inundated a Seneca reservation in callous abrogation of a treaty signed by George Washington himself. Listen to this last and you will feel a flush of honest shame. La Farge has fashioned a sad and bitter record, one that strikes the heart like an arrow."[42]

La Farge was found dead in his New York apartment on October 27, 1965, due to causes that remain uncertain. In his obituary, the *New York Times* noted: "Although he recorded six albums, mostly of his own material, Mr. La Farge achieved his major success as a writer. His prolific output was dominated by Western themes, particularly the plight of the Indian. Some of his friends even thought he was part Indian, although his lineage could be traced back to Benjamin Franklin."[43]

A Leading Bluegrass Band

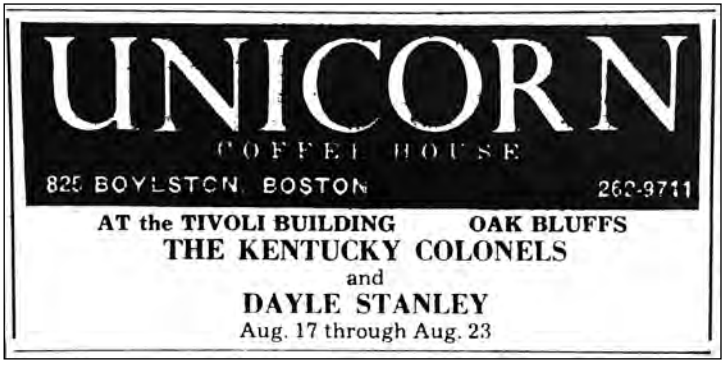
The Kentucky Colonels were a bluegrass band consisting of Clarence White on guitar, his brother Roland on mandolin, Billy Ray Latham on banjo, and Roger Bush on bass. Fiddler Bobby Slone may also have played with them during their Vineyard appearance. A couple of months earlier, the Colonels had played a two-week stint at the Boston branch of the Unicorn, and in July, at an evening concert during the 1964 Newport Folk Festival, their set had been slotted between sets by Pete Seeger and Mississippi John Hurt.

41 Sandra Hale Schulman, *The Ballad of Peter La Farge* (documentary film), 2010.

42 *High Fidelity*, July 1963, 70.

43 "Peter La Farge, 33, Folk Song Writer, Is Found Dead Here," *New York Times*, October 20, 1965, 52.

Clarence and Roland White were originally from Maine. Their French-Canadian father, who played fiddle and banjo, would take the boys out on weekends to perform at local Grange halls. In 1954 the family moved to Burbank, California, where they played on a talent show and won it. Along with their brother Eric on tenor banjo, they called themselves the Country Boys and appeared on two early episodes of *The Andy Griffith Show*. The group entered the folk music world via the Ash Grove in Los Angeles. According to Roland, the Country Boys were the first bluegrass group ever to play at that major folk venue. They were brought in to play one set, but the management invited them back for two week-long appearances, first with the New Lost City Ramblers and then with the Tarriers. After a hiatus caused by Roland being drafted, the group reconstituted itself and changed their name to the Kentucky Colonels.[44]



Advertisement in the Vineyard Gazette, August 18, 1964.

Writing in the *Broadside of Boston* prior to one of the Colonels' gigs at Club 47 in Cambridge, critic Dick Waterman had noted: "In these times of pathos and misery among folk singers, it is reassuring and heartening to find a group that sings—and sings well—simply because they enjoy doing it and are having a rollicking good time." Waterman also noted that the Colonels "have learned to combine good country music with stage presence and honest fun." In what Waterman described as "a masterpiece of showmanship" and "an audience-grabber that can crack even the most sedate house," a special banjo duet would have Latham and Bush each picking on his own instrument while doing his left-handed fingering on the other player's instrument.[45]

More important to the Colonels' notoriety than their on-stage hijinks, or even their excellent harmonies, was their musicianship. Clarence was of particular note in this regard. Whereas the guitar had previously been strictly a rhythm instrument within the bluegrass genre, it was Clarence's speed and prowess as a picker that were pivotal in establishing the guitar

44 Eric Von Schmidt and Jim Rooney, *Baby, Let Me Follow You Down: The Illustrated Story of The Cambridge Folk Years* (Anchor Books, 1979), 208-209.
45 *Broadside of Boston,* vol. 2, no. 20 (December 11, 1963), 3.

as a solo bluegrass instrument. "Inspired by virtuoso flatpicker Doc Watson, Clarence reimagined the role of the guitar in bluegrass, transforming it from a strictly rhythmic vehicle to a more expansive instrument on which lead and rhythm could be played simultaneously."[46]

When the Kentucky Colonels played at the Unicorn, they had already released two record albums. The group continued for another two years, and then disbanded. Roland White later played with bands led by bluegrass legends Bill Monroe and Lester Flatts. For 13 years he was a member of Country Gazette. Clarence White joined the Byrds as lead guitarist in 1968 and was the group's second longest-serving member, after Roger McGuinn. In 1973 he was killed by a drunk driver while loading equipment into his vehicle. Roger Bush later formed the Country Gazette with Byron Berline, and Billy Ray Latham later joined the Dillards.

A Boston Favorite

Like the Kentucky Colonels, Weymouth native Dayle Stanley came to the Vineyard shortly after a two-week stint at the Boston Unicorn. Stanley was by that time an established figure on the Boston-Cambridge music scene, and a year earlier she had garnered the distinction of being selected as Boston's Most Popular Female Folk Artist, based on a poll taken by the *Broadside of Boston*.[47] Her first record album (*Child of Hollow Times*), had been released in 1963, and her second one (*After the Snow*) was recorded and released a few months following her Vineyard appearance.

Stanley's promise as a vocalist had been evident at a young age. Her mother had hoped that Stanley might study voice under Mme. Emilia Ippolito, founder of Boston's Bel Canto School of Voice and Opera and voice teacher at the Boston University School of Music. However, Ippolito did not take on children as students. Through the persistence of Stanley's mother, Ippolito finally agreed to at least listen to the eleven-year-old girl sing. Ippolito was sufficiently impressed to make an exception and accepted young Stanley as a student. By age 13, Stanley had developed a well-trained operatic voice with a four-octave range.[48]

Stanley's formal musical education was disrupted by frequent family moves between Massachusetts and Florida, but as a teenager she took up the guitar and began writing music and lyrics. She credited Harry Belafonte as the key influence on her movement into folk music.[49] Her first public performances as a folk singer were at the Green Frog on Kenmore Square in Boston in 1960 or 1961. When that club closed in 1962, Stanley was welcomed

46 Bill Friskics-Warren, *Boston Globe*, April 9, 2022, C10.
47 *Broadside of Boston,* vol. 3, no. 6 (May 13, 1964).
48 Dayle Stanley, *Broadcast Radio Interview with Thomas Curren, Betsy Siggins, and Host Bob Weiser*, WOMR (Provincetown, MA), April 10, 2017.
49 Stanley, *Broadcast Radio Interview.*

to the stage of Club 47 in Cambridge, where she shared the bill with acts that included Tom Rush, the Charles River Valley Boys, and Geoff Muldaur.

In its review of Stanley's first album, the *New York Times* described her as "a solo newcomer worth attention" and "obviously an important talent" with "an outstanding soprano voice." The *Times* also found her songwriting to be "strong melodically and courageous in content."[50]

After 1965, Stanley curtailed substantially her public performances. Appearances in Boston and Vermont in 1969 and 1970 may have been her last.[51] Stanley moved on to other interests, which included raising and showing horses and painting. She died in 2021 at age 81.

Of all the headliners who performed at the Vineyard Unicorn, only Stanley actually wrote a song about being on the Vineyard. Her song "Cry, The Mountains White" is a lament about her husband Stephen being in the mountains of New Hampshire while she is without him on the Vineyard. The lyrics culminate with this sentiment: "When you return, when you return, we will find our place in the Vineyard so low."[52] To date this song seems to be the only cut from Stanley's two albums that has been reissued. It appears on the compilation recording entitled *Women Blue: 16 Lost US Femvox Classics*, which was released in 2009.[53]

A Sunday-Night Hoot

Like most coffee houses of the era, the Vineyard branch of the Unicorn set aside one evening each week for Hootenanny Night, at which the program consisted mostly—or more often, entirely—of unpaid amateurs who showed up and performed without any requirement to audition beforehand. In 1964 the "hoot" at the Tivoli was held on Sunday nights.

I had the good fortune of being in attendance for one of those hoots at the Tivoli. What drew me there was the first-ever public performance by a trio of 15/16-year-old female friends from the Campground. They were Christine Harmon, Day Merrill, and Cheryl Roedel.[54] The first song the

50 *New York Times*, August 23, 1964, X 17.

51 *Brattleboro Reformer*, May 1, 1969, 1; *Boston Globe*, June 10, 1969, 35; *Burlington Free Press*, February 12, 1970, 12.

52 Stanley's second husband, Stephen Scotti, who collaborated with her on writing the material for her second album, also wrote the liner notes. In those notes he described the song this way: "Dayle's song of Parting and Returning; Of the White Mountains in New Hampshire and Martha's Vineyard off Cape Cod; Of opposite symbols and composite yearnings in a youthful time."

53 Past & Present Records, #2105.

54 Christine Harmon is the daughter of actress Patricia Peardon, who had appeared on the cover of *Life* magazine on December 15, 1941. Day Merrill is the daughter of Steve Merrill, a professional photographer and amateur magician who wrote a folksy newspaper column in Portland, Maine, and who recorded an album of Maine humor entitled *Father Fell Down the Well*. Cheryl Roedel,

trio offered up was an obscure one called "Oedipus Blues," which must have been selected either for its shock value or because the young singers did not grasp the full import of the lyrics. The other song they did that night was "House of the Rising Sun." That song had decades-old roots, but a new British version by the Animals had burst onto the cultural landscape just two months earlier, helping to usher in the era of folk-rock. The young female trio did a quite respectable version of it that night, although some of the males in the audience reported afterward that they found it odd that young women would sing about a brothel. Apparently, those young men did not appreciate that historically the song had been shaped at some times from a male perspective but at other times from a female one.

Amid the congratulations following the performance of the young trio, we failed to hear the introduction of the next act to go on. But soon we could not help but notice there were two quirky but arrestingly talented musicians on stage, one playing fiddle and the other guitar. It was not until years later that I discovered this memorable pair to have been none other than the Holy Modal Rounders (Peter Stampfel and Steve Weber), who were headliners that week at Café Moska, a rival coffee house in Vineyard Haven.[55]

To encourage participation and to add a bit of drama to the weekly hootenannies at the Unicorn, the owners offered prizes to the first-, second-, and third-place winners for the season. All three would receive a one-week engagement at the Boston Unicorn, and the first-place winner would also receive $100, plus the opportunity to appear on an unspecified "major Boston TV show."

At one of the hoots in August, winners were to be selected. Among those aspiring to garner the top prize were Nancy and Allan Crossley from the Campground. A jug band also competed; it was formed by Dave Seward and included his brother Doug, along with John Combra and John Hurd.[56] The hopes of these and all other contenders were quickly dashed when Jamie Taylor and Danny "Kootch" Kortchmar had their turn at the microphone. As DeMont later reported, Taylor and Kortchmar won first prize "hands down."

A Grocery Store Promotion

The final headlining act for the 1964 season at the Unicorn was a seven-member group called the New Prince Spaghetti Minstrels. Members at the time of their appearance on the Vineyard were Katie deBettencourt

who died in 2014, was the daughter of Paul and Carolyn Roedel, who lived on the Campground in 1964 and later on East Chop.

55 W. Douglas Thompson, "Café Moska: A Folk Music Venture on Union Street in 1964," *Martha's Vineyard Museum Quarterly*, May 2020, 16-23.

56 Thomas Dresser and Jerold Muskin, *Music on Martha's Vineyard: A History of Harmony* (The History Press, 2014), 56-57.

of Natick, Fred Dill of Pittsburgh PA, George Hallisey of Jamaica Plain, Robert Mazetta of Madison CT, Carol Metcalfe of Milton, John Neyes of Roxbury, and Paul Toner of Marshfield. Katie deBettencourt, daughter of William deBettencourt and Mary Connor deBettencourt, was born on the Vineyard and had attended the Oak Bluffs School prior to her family moving to Natick when she was entering the fifth grade.[57]

As a freshman at Stonehill College in the fall of 1963, Katie deBettencourt had met fellow students Carol Metcalfe, Robert Mazetta, and George Hallisey, and they formed a folk-singing quartet. Meanwhile, Stan Freberg, the well-known comedian and innovative creator of jingles and humorous commercials for radio and television, had been hired by the Prince Spaghetti Company to design a new advertising campaign. A popular folk group at the time was the New Christy Minstrels, so Freberg proposed getting attention for Prince by evoking the name recognition of that established group and therefore formed the New Prince Spaghetti Minstrels.

A scout for Prince had seen the deBettencourt/Metcalfe/Mazetta/Hallisey quartet at a hootenanny on Cape Cod, and Prince eventually signed them, along with Fred Dill, John Neyes, and Paul Toner. The all-acoustic instruments included three guitars, a banjo, and a bass fiddle.

The contract that the Spaghetti Minstrels signed committed the group to a rigorous schedule of appearances throughout New England. Many of their concerts took place in the parking lots of supermarkets, and some even in the aisles of the stores themselves.

For the duration of their contract with Prince, the Spaghetti Minstrels were also obliged to incorporate into their act the jingles that were written by Freberg and that sang the praises of Prince's products (e.g., "Yellow Is the Color of My True Love's Noodle"). However, the Spaghetti Minstrels were not an actual parody of the Christy Minstrels; like the earlier group, they aspired to—and achieved—musical excellence that showcased a broad repertoire of folk songs. Dill was responsible for the arrangements of most of the group's material, and Hallisey handled the business end of their touring.

The group rapidly expanded its appearances beyond New England and did concerts in Rochester, Cleveland, and Detroit. On one Thursday in July, shortly before their appearance on the Vineyard, the group had performed at five locations in New Jersey: Beachwood at 10:30, Brick Town at 1:00, Point Pleasant at 2:30, Neptune City at 4:00, and Freehold at 7:00. A few days later the group did two shows at the New York World's Fair. On August 3, they appeared on *The Mike Douglas Show*, although the producers would not allow John Neyes, the group's only person of color, to

57 Several members of Katie deBettencourt's extended family currently reside on the Vineyard, and some of them operate auto repair businesses on Munroe and Winthrop Avenues in Oak Bluffs and a gas station on New York Avenue.

perform. The group traveled in a Volkswagen bus with John's standup bass strapped to the roof. Occasionally, the two women would leave the overloaded bus to the men and would drive separately.

The opening act for the appearance of the Spaghetti Minstrels at the Vineyard Unicorn was Jamie & Kootch, winners of the amateur contest at the Unicorn's hootenannies. If Jamie & Kootch were paid for their role in warming up the crowd, then it could have been 16-year-old James Taylor's second professional gig. Back in July, Taylor had been paid $20 for performing at Café Moska in Vineyard Haven.[58]

When the Spaghetti Minstrels left the Island at the end of their engagement, they had not been paid. After subsequent efforts to contact Papadopoulo proved unsuccessful, they eventually showed up *en masse* at the Boston Unicorn and refused to leave until Papadopoulo came through with the money they were owed.

Subsequent to their appearance of the Vineyard, the Spaghetti Minstrels underwent some changes in personnel. Bass player John Neves left to pursue his major musical interest, which was jazz. Steve Bailey was hired on as the new bassist, Paul Toner was replaced by Alex Lukeman, and Deneen Clark joined after Katie deBettencourt left the group. The group performed on the CBS television show *On Broadway Tonight*, appearing with such major stars as Judy Garland, Rudy Vallee, and George Carlin. On the road they opened for the Beach Boys and Jerry Vale, and they played the Thunderbird in Las Vegas. The group's only recording other than jingles for Prince was a single 45 rpm record for Kapp.

Another Relocation

The 1964 season of the Unicorn marked the last gasp for the decrepit Tivoli. On August 21 it was announced in the *Gazette* that the Town of Oak Bluffs would be acquiring the building, and on December 3 the Board of Selectmen accepted a bid of $1,850 for its demolition. On December 19 the process of taking down the Tivoli began in advance of groundbreaking for the construction of a new town hall.[59]

In the spring of 1965, George and Virginia Papadopoulo came down to the Vineyard to join DeMont in finding a new venue. On May 13 Papadopoulo appeared before the selectmen regarding possible lease of the MacMackin Building as the new location for the Unicorn, and on June 3 he received unanimous approval.

The interior of the MacMackin Building (157 Circuit Avenue, which once had housed the Oak Bluffs Library, and which currently houses the Rockland Trust Bank) was at that time in poor condition. *Gazette* colum-

58 Thompson, "Café Moska."

59 The former town hall that was built on the site of the Tivoli is currently the headquarters of the Oak Bluffs Police Department.



The Unicorn Coffee House in its third location, currently numbered 157 Circuit Avenue.

nist Louise Aldrich Bugbee reported that in late June "the place was a mess of fallen plaster, piles of lumber and confusion." However, when Bugbee attended a show on July 6, she was amazed to find a venue that "had the look of an 18th century tavern with dark beams, trestle tables, red drapes at the windows and amber lanterns hanging from the beams."[60] She went on to recommend to her readers that homeowners who found it taking "forever" to get minor repairs done should contact the contractor who remodeled the Unicorn.

Bugbee later learned that those who accomplished the transformation were not in fact for hire. The work was performed by Charles Nickerson, a seminarian from the Philip Neri School in Boston who had been hired to manage the Unicorn. When hired, Nickerson had not realized that he would have to "build the place" before getting to actually manage it. Assisting him in the project were local teenagers Dave Robinson, Dave Whitney, and Ruth Whitney.[61]

In 1965 all drinks at the Unicorn were priced at 75 cents. Management did not charge for admission but imposed a $1.50 minimum. Bugbee noted in her Gazette column that "no cup of coffee is worth seventy-five cents," but she urged potential customers to recognize that "the entertainment provided is and must be paid for."[62]

Headlining performers during the 1965 season were Sandy Baron, Jesse Colin Young, Jerry Corbitt, Josh White, the Chambers Brothers, and Casey Anderson.

60 Louise Aldrich Bugbee, *Vineyard Gazette*, July 9, 1965, 1-A.
61 Louise Aldrich Bugbee, *Vineyard Gazette*, July 16, 1965, 5-A.
62 Louise Aldrich Bugbee, *Vineyard Gazette*, July 16, 1965, 5-A



Headlining acts at the Unicorn in 1965: Sandy Baron, Jesse Colin Young, Jerry Corbitt, Josh White, The Chambers Brothers (Willie, Joe, Lester, and George), and Casey Anderson.

A Stand-Up Comic

One of the three performers who together opened the 1965 season at the Unicorn was comedian Sandy Baron. Although the coffee houses of the period focused almost exclusively on folk music, occasionally comedians were booked as well. For example, as early as 1962, comedian Woody Allen had appeared at the Bitter End in Greenwich Village.[63]

Baron, the son of Russian immigrants, was born Sanford Beresofsky in 1936 and began his career doing stand-up comedy in the hotels of the Catskill Mountains resorts. He soon became a frequent guest on television talk shows, such as *The Merv Griffin Show* and *The Mike Douglas Show*. He also was featured in the popular U. S. version of the weekly British satirical show *That Was the Week That Was*, starring David Frost. These television credits were noted prominently in the ad placed in the Gazette to announce Baron's stint at the Vineyard Unicorn.

One enthusiastic fan of Baron's comedy appearance at the Unicorn was Louise Aldrich Bugbee. In her *Gazette* column "On Circuit Avenue and All About the Town," she quipped that, although Baron had "lampooned the stuffing out of everybody and everything, he has a lot of faith in the human race and in our country and the future of both." Bugbee recommended that hard-working local business people in Oak Bluffs should check out Baron's act, urging them to "treat yourselves to laughter and

63 *New York Times*, November 21, 1962, 26.

you will weather the season better."[64]

Subsequent to his appearance at the Unicorn, Baron continued working as a stand-up comic. Recordings of his routines highlighted his humorous take on such serious subjects as education, race relations, religion, and homosexuality. He starred on Broadway as Lenny Bruce and appeared as a character actor in numerous plays and films. Baron died in 2001 and seems to be currently remembered most for his role as Jack Klompus, the nemesis of Jerry's father Morty on the hit television series *Seinfeld*.



Poster announcing three performers at the Unicorn in 1965

A New Collaboration

On the bill with Baron at the Unicorn were musicians Jesse Colin Young and Jerry Corbitt, who at the time were traveling together throughout North America exploring a collaboration that they hoped might form the nucleus of a new folk-rock group. Young's appearance at the Unicorn was apparently the first time that he had performed on the Vineyard, but during the previous summer Corbitt had been featured as a solo act at the Moon-Cusser Coffee House, sharing the bill with the Country Gentlemen, a bluegrass group based in Washington, D.C. At the time of their appearance at the Vineyard Unicorn, Young was 23, and Corbitt was 22.

New York native Young, whose real name is Perry Miller, attended Phillips Andover Academy and had aspired to be a writer, but in college decided he was not cut out for that profession. He was drawn to music and was befriended by pianist and record producer Bobby Scott, who became the primary facilitator of Young's career. Scott took Young to singer Bobby Darin's production company and paid for 4 hours of studio time to record 11 of Young's songs, six of which were original compositions. The resulting album (*The Soul Of A City Boy*) was sold to Columbia and released in 1964. A few months before his appearance at the Unicorn, Young's second album (*Young Blood*) had also been released.

Writing in the *Fort Worth Star-Telegram*, Grover Lewis described Young's second recording as "a fresh and altogether exceptional album

64 Louise Aldrich Bugbee, *Vineyard Gazette*, July 9, 1965, 1-A.

… by a fresh and altogether exceptional young singer." Lewis went on to describe Young as "singing with a visceral urgency and intensity that few seasoned talents can ever hope to command."[65]

In the summer of 1965, Georgia native Corbitt had not yet put out a record, but he and Young clearly were feeling comfortable together both musically and personally, so they moved quickly in recruiting Lowell "Banana" Levinger and Joe Bauer to join them in forming their new group, the Youngbloods. The group is best remembered for its version of Dino Valenti's song "Get Together," which became a peace-love anthem in the late 1960s. Both Young and Corbitt later pursued solo careers. Corbitt was also active as a record producer. Among the albums that he produced was the first album by Don McLean, who, like Corbitt, had performed on the Vineyard in 1964 at the Moon-Cusser. Corbitt died of lung cancer in 2014.

Twenty-two years after his appearance at the Unicorn, Young returned to the Vineyard to perform at the Vineyard Peace Concert '86, which was held at the Regional High School football field and was hosted by Hugh Taylor and Judy Belushi. Other performers included The Band, Holly Near, Jon Pousette-Dart, Urban Blight, Cheryl Wheeler, and Carly Simon. Then-Senator John Kerry gave a speech at the event.[66]

A Charismatic Pioneer

Josh White, a native of Greenville, South Carolina, was born in 1914. By age eight, he had left home to travel with blind street performers for whom he served as a "lead boy" and as the assistant who would collect coins for the musician in a cup or tambourine. White's earnings on the road were sent home to his mother by his employer. Along the way, White learned to play the guitar and developed himself as a vocalist. While leading for Blind Joe Taggart in Chicago, he was given the opportunity to play guitar and sing on a recording that Taggart made in 1928. White's long recording career was thereby launched at age 14.[67]

In 1940 White's career had been boosted substantially by his becoming a regular cast member on a CBS radio program called *Back Where I Come From*, along with Woody Guthrie, Leadbelly, and Burl Ives. He also became a regular performer at Cafe Society, New York City's first fully integrated nightclub.[68]

White went on to play at inaugural events for Franklin Roosevelt, at the Apollo Theatre and Town Hall in New York and at similarly renowned venues in cities across the U.S. and abroad. Wherever he performed, it was not only his music but also his personal magnetism that wowed his

65 *Fort Worth Star-Telegram*, April 18, 1965.
66 *Martha's Vineyard Times*, July 27, 2016.
67 Wald, *Josh White*.
68 Wald, *Josh White*.

audiences. In the *New York Times*, Carter B. Horsley observed that "Mr. White's amiable, suave and sophisticated renditions of American spiritual and blues songs made folk songs the music of urban cabarets in the 1940s when he reached the zenith of his popularity… Mr. White captivated audiences with his casual charm and his authoritatively sensual style. He invariably performed in clubs or concerts seated on a stool, with his foot propped on one of the rungs, and wearing an open shirt."[69]

White's protest songs and his support of liberal causes helped to make him a target of the House Committee on Un-American Activities, before which he testified in 1950. Constraints imposed on White's career during the McCarthy Era of blacklisting persisted until 1963. In that year he was invited to perform on the television special *Dinner with the President*, hosted by President John F. Kennedy, and he also performed at the March on Washington in August where Martin Luther King, Jr. gave his "I Have a Dream" speech. He appeared twice on ABC's nationally televised show *Hootenanny*, and was again touring extensively both nationally and internationally. During this period, however, White was plagued by worsening heart disease.[70]

In 1965, the Vineyard Unicorn booked White for three nights—Friday, Saturday, and Sunday, July 23-25.[71] White was also scheduled to perform three times that same weekend at the Newport Folk Festival: at its Thursday evening concert and at afternoon workshops on Friday and Saturday. Unfortunately, White's heart condition necessitated his being admitted to hospital just days before these two sets of commitments. He had to cancel his two afternoon appearances at Newport, and he was able to move his concert appearance there from Thursday evening to Sunday evening.[72] Those changes of course meant that White's appearance at the Unicorn would be limited to two nights, Friday and Saturday.

Perhaps literally because of delays in White getting discharged from the hospital on that Friday, White and his road manager (and possibly his bass player as well) missed their scheduled ferry from Woods Hole to the Vineyard on Friday night and had to make the crossing much later than planned. In its next week's edition, the *Gazette* reported that White had "unavoidably kept a crowd of more than 100 waiting at the Unicorn for the scheduled performance. He arrived in good spirits and good voice, and the entertainment was worth the time spent waiting."[73]

White died in 1969. Twenty-nine years later, as part of its series "Legends of American Music," the U.S. Postal Service issued a sheet of stamps honoring folk musicians White, Woody Guthrie, Leadbelly, and Sonny Terry.

69 Carter B. Horsley, *New York Times*, September 6, 1969, 29.
70 Elijah Wald, 2000.
71 *Vineyard Gazette*, July 23, 1965, 5.
72 Elijah Wald, correspondence, February 5, 2023.
73 *Vineyard Gazette*, July 30, 1965, 7-A.

A Sensation at Newport

The Chambers Brothers (Willie, Joe, Lester, and George) grew up in Carthage, Mississippi, where they worked on their father's farm with their nine brothers and sisters. They sang in church and in the fields. The four boys would also perform for white folks. They later recalled that, when they finished singing, the white man would pull out an apple and offer it to them as payment, but before giving it to them, he took a bite of it. That was to "remind them of their place."[74]

In the mid-1950s, the brothers had moved to California, where they performed gospel and folk music with Willie and Joe on guitar, Lester on harmonica, and George on washtub bass. For nearly a decade they performed almost exclusively in southern California. However, their frequent appearances at the Ash Grove, a popular folk venue in Los Angeles, brought them into contact with many of the nationally prominent folk singers of the day. Among these was Barbara Dane, who recorded an album with the four brothers and intervened with Pete Seeger to get them booked for the 1965 Newport Folk Festival.

In the opinion of Ernie Santosuosso, critic for the *Boston Globe*, the Chambers Brothers were "this year's sleepers of the Newport Folk Festival."[75] "They were one of the three or four most exciting acts." "And their sound—call it rhythm and blues, rock-'n-roll or folk-rock—came from an electric outlet. Their guitars twanged into Narragansett Bay and the crowd, all 18,000, stomped for more."[76]

Following their appearance at the Vineyard Unicorn, at which they may have been joined by drummer Brian Keenan, the Chambers Brother went directly to a four-week stint at the Boston Unicorn. Shortly thereafter their album with Barbara Dane was released, as was the first album of their own. Much of their music became a decidedly psychedelic brand of soul, but they also remained faithful to their gospel roots, appearing, for example, with Maria Muldaur on her *Gospel Nights* album.

The greatest commercial success that the Chambers Brothers achieved was the single version of the title song from their first studio album *The Time Has Come*. It reached #11 on the *Billboard* Hot 100 in the fall of 1968.

A Versatile Singer and Songwriter

The performer who closed out the 1965 summer season at the Vineyard Unicorn was Casey Anderson. Anderson was born in Oklahoma and grew

74 *Broadside of Boston,* vol. 4, no. 13 (August 18, 1965); Barbara Dane, "The Chamber Brothers Do That Real Thing," *Sing Out!*, vol. 15, no. 4 (September, 1965), 22-24.

75 Ernie Santosuosso, *Boston Globe*, November 21, 1965.

76 Ernie Santosuosso, *Boston Globe*, October 10, 1965.

up in Alabama. He had had a short career in teaching and had served a stint in the military during the Korean War. He first came to the attention of New England folk music fans in 1961, when he appeared at the Golden Vanity Coffee House on the campus of Boston University. He was based in New York and wrote a column about the burgeoning folk music scene there for the *Broadside of Boston*.[77]

In the summer of 1965, Anderson came to the Vineyard directly from an engagement at the Boston Unicorn. He had already put out six studio albums and one live album, which was recorded at the famous Ice House in Pasadena, California. Anderson had also put out several 45 rpm singles and a "festival album" with Oscar Brand, Jean Ritchie, and others. He had appeared on the Dave Garroway's *Today Show* and *The Jack Paar Show*, and he had toured on the Playboy Club circuit. Anderson wrote and published dozens of songs in myriad styles, including country & western, pop, blues, and calypso.[78]

Anderson covered material from a wide range of songwriters, including Woody Guthrie, Jerome Kern, Fred Neil, Jimmie Cox, Leroy Carr, and Shel Silverstein. He was unapologetic for his eclectic choice of material and his multiple stylistic modes. On the liner notes of his live album, he stated: "I have a great love for many different kinds of folk music, and would feel equally comfortable recording any of them… For reasons that have not been entirely explored, the public seems to prefer an artist it can easily label. It wants to know him not as a performer who can successfully handle a variety of material, but rather an artist who can quickly be thought of as a blues singer, a ballad man, a classical folk singer, a protest man, a folk comedian, or whatever… I've always strongly believed that the truly great performing artist is ultimately a versatile one."[79]

Following his appearance on the Vineyard, Anderson continued to tour and record. He died in 1989 at age 54 due to complications from severe diabetes.

A Major Impresario

When devoted fans of folk music returned to Oak Bluffs in the summer of 1966, the large "UNICORN" sign on the façade of the MacMackin Building was gone; there was to be no third season for the coffee house. Nick's Lighthouse, which had previously been located where Ben and Bill's Chocolate Emporium is located today, moved into the space vacated by the Unicorn. The other Oak Bluffs folk venue, the Moon-Cusser Coffee House had also gone out of business, and its space was taken over by The Vineyard Wine Shop.

77 *Broadside of Boston*, vol. 2, no. 4 (April 19, 1963), 3.

78 "Home Town Boy to Perform In Benefit Concert", *Okmulgee (Oklahoma) Daily Times*, April 12, 1964, 3; *Broadside of Boston*, vol. 2, no. 4 (April 19, 1963), 3.

79 Casey Anderson, liner notes for *Casey Anderson 'Live' At The Ice House*, ATCO 33-172, 1965.

Following the closure of the Vineyard branch of the Unicorn, Papadopoulo continued operating the Unicorn in Boston for several years. He also continued to promote ticketed concerts in larger venues and opened two additional clubs, the Psychedelic Supermarket in Boston and the Electric Ballroom in Cambridge. In 1967, *Billboard* magazine announced that Papadopoulo was to be the producer for a huge 4-day event known as the American Musical Festival. The editors noted that PapadopouIo was at the time still "one of Boston's top popular and folk music impresarios" and was "president of Unicorn Coffee House Productions, publisher of three magazines, and head of an advertising agency serving youth in music and the arts."[80] For many years Papadopoulo was also active in the United Nations' Model U.N. program.

In 1972 Papadopoulo returned to Greece, where he established a company to help Greek students with the process of applying for admission to colleges in the United States. The final phase of his varied professional life was as advisor to the Finance Minister of the Bahamas, where he died in 1992.

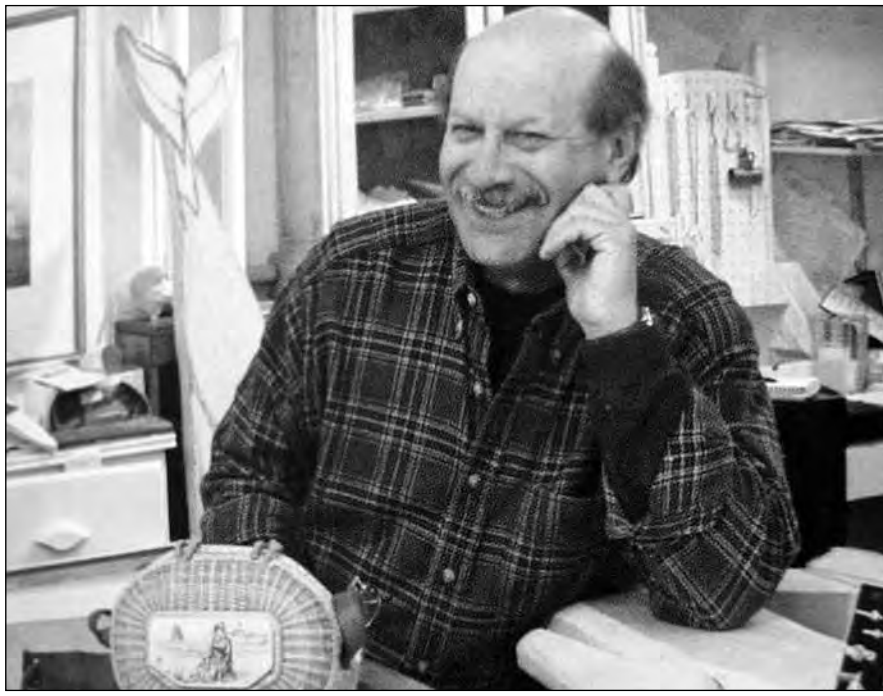
Thirty years after her husband's death, his wife Virginia reflected on Papadopoulo's involvement in the New England folk music community. "He was loved and despised equally, and truly understood by few. Those who really knew him, loved him. Those who didn't, saw him as an opportunist… Sadly, George was not accepted in the folk scene, and he felt it was because he was foreign. Foreign or not, the night we were married he had Ian and Sylvia at one concert hall in Boston, Judy Collins at Symphony Hall, and Josh White Sr. in the Unicorn."

A Life Devoted to the Arts

Following the second of the Vineyard Unicorn's two seasons, Tom DeMont decided to put his background in art education to use and secured a teaching position in Walpole. But he could not stay away from the Vineyard long-term. After four years in Walpole he returned to the Island and opened a series of businesses, including sign-painting, a small advertising firm, and a series of two art galleries in Vineyard Haven. For one of his galleries, he partnered with his college roommate, Enrico Vittorio Pinardi, who later became a renowned sculptor, a professor at Rhode Island College, and an investor in Vineyard businesses that included the Pequot Hotel and the Lamppost Bar in Oak Bluffs. DeMont himself had a number of one-man shows of his own art on the Vineyard.

DeMont also became interested in musical theater. He was a key volunteer in establishing a program in the dramatic arts at the Martha's Vineyard Regional High School, where he helped to secure a grant from Massachusetts Arts and Humanities for a year-long theater-in-residence

80 "Boston Papers Getting Into Cultural Act; Backing Fests," *Billboard*, January 7, 1967, 24.



Tom DeMont, scrimshaw artist, circa 2009

program at the high school and in which he served as set designer. As both set designer and actor, he collaborated with Duncan Ross and others in development of the original Vineyard Players.

In the 1980s DeMont teamed up with Ross, Marty Nadler, and Michael West to write the story and music for an original musical comedy called "Tivoli." The musical was both a love story and a mystery, with much of the action taking place at the Tivoli in Oak Bluffs. The team sold public stock in the enterprise, but ultimately it proved not to be financially viable, and the musical was never actually produced.

For the final three decades of his life, DeMont was a nationally known and highly sought-after scrimshaw artist and proprietor of a gallery in Edgartown where he sold his own work and the work of a large and diverse group of visual artists whom he represented.

A Final Word

In its brief two-summer run, the Vineyard Unicorn provided its mostly young audiences with an impressive array of top folk singers and instrumentalists in an intimate, informal, alcohol-free setting. Those customers who came back repeatedly were able to experience a wide variety of musical traditions and techniques. They heard folk songs from many regions of North America and from countries around the world, songs of love

and of loss, songs passed down through many generations, songs newly penned, and songs that boldly confronted issues of race, injustice, poverty, and war. They witnessed up close instrumental wizards, some who had been born before the turn of the century and others who were barely out of their teens.

In terms of the composition of the roster of the Unicorn, it was heavily tilted toward male performers, which was not atypical in the folk musical field at the time. Joan Baez was deservedly a superstar, but it was difficult for many other extremely talented women to gain a foothold in folk music. Most all who tried were inevitably compared to Baez. A frustrated Dayle Stanley actually cut off her long hair in a desperate attempt to help discourage such comparisons.[81] The two solo female folk-singers who performed at the Vineyard Unicorn (Dayle Stanley and Bonnie Dobson) distinguished themselves from Baez in one key artistic way. Both began writing some of their own material early in their careers, whereas Baez did not began doing so until late in the 1960s. Audiences at the Unicorn were fortunate to hear that original material performed in person.

The weekly hootenannies at the Unicorn were a huge hit and made it possible for young aspiring singers and instrumentalists to gain valuable experience performing before a live audience. Many of the friends that amateur performers brought along for moral support on hootenanny night gave the Unicorn an opportunity to engage a weekly crop of first-time customers.

The Vineyard Unicorn was a vibrant place operating in a time of great changes in folk music and in American musical tastes in general. Before the Unicorn first opened its doors in 1964 the Beatles had already taken the country by storm with their February appearance on *The Ed Sullivan Show*. And when Josh White left the Vineyard after playing at the Unicorn, he went directly to Newport and played at the very concert where, earlier in the evening, Bob Dylan had shocked the folk world by famously "going electric."[82]

81 Thomas S. Curren, *I Believe I'll Go Back Home: Roots and Revival in New England Folk Music* (Bright Leaf [An Imprint of University of Massachusetts Press], 2021), 157.

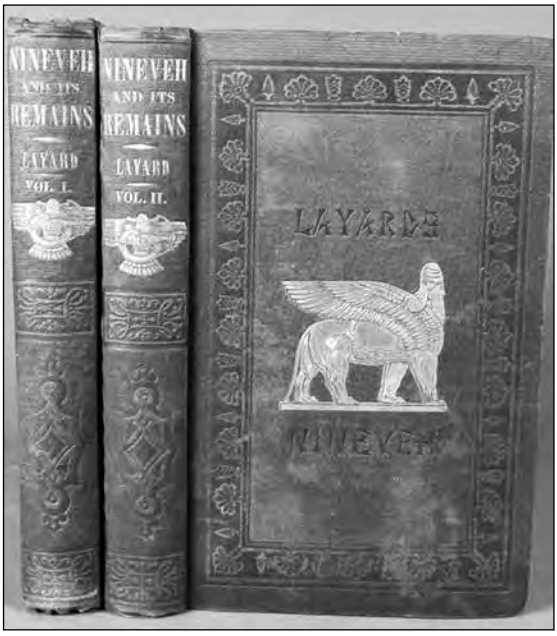
82 Elijah Wald, *Dylan Goes Electric* (HarperCollins, 2015).

Nineveh and Babylon On the Vineyard: The Significance of Abigail W. Daggett's 1853 Assyrian Archaeology Book

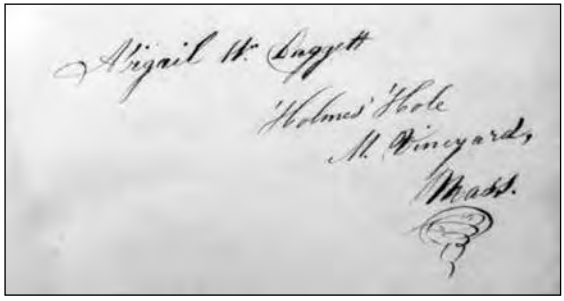
by Aidan D. Charron
and James B. Richardson III

In 2011, at the annual book sale run by the Friends of the West Tisbury Public Library, Jim Richardson purchased a copy of *Discoveries Among the Ruins of Nineveh and Babylon* by Austin H. Layard, published in New York by Harpers and Brothers in 1853. The name of the former owner was inscribed on the first and last page: "Abigail W. Daggett, of Holmes Hole, M. Vineyard." Several years later, he discovered a copy of another of Layard's works on the Vineyard: the two-volume *Nineveh and Its Remains*, published in 1849 by George Putnam and Co in New York. The two-volume set was once part of the lending library of the Bradley Memorial Church in Oak Bluffs. They had been salvaged by Linsey Lee, oral history curator at the Martha's Vineyard Museum, when the Museum was sorting through the contents of the church building (shuttered since 1966) prior to its sale.

Aidan Charron is a 2024 graduate of Hope College in Holland, MI with a degree in Christian History and Theology and is the grandson of the co-author. Jim Richardson is an archaeologist who has conducted research on the Vineyard and in Peru. He is an emeritus chief curator of anthropology, Carnegie Museum of Natural History and emeritus professor of anthropology, University of Pittsburgh. Five generations of his family have lived on the Vineyard, and he has been involved with the museum since the 1950s. The authors thank Anna Barber, Catherine Mayhew and Dana Street of the Martha's Vineyard Museum for their help in the researching Abigail W. Daggett, and Dr. Timothy Larsen, Carolyn and Fred McManis Professor of Christian Thought and Professor of History at Wheaton College, for providing key references used in writing this article.



Above, Layard's two books.
Below, Abigail Daggett's inscription.



Abigail W. Daggett was born in the village of Holmes Hole (now Vineyard Haven) on August 5, 1798, and died on February 14, 1878, at the age of 79. Discussing the history of schools in nineteenth-century Tisbury, historian Charles Banks says that, of the town's many private-school teachers, "Chief among these must be mentioned the late Abigail W. Daggett who taught in the 40's and 50's."[1] This suggests that Abigail Daggett never married, since during this period female teachers who did so had to leave the profession. Her father was Michael Daggett (1770-1852), a Tisbury husbandman (livestock farmer) and her mother was Elizabeth Butler (1775-1804), also of Tisbury. Her father, Michael, had five brothers all of whom were mariners and all of whom were lost at sea—the three oldest on the privateer brig *General Arnold* when she was wrecked off Plymouth in 1778.[2] Her middle initial W, visible in her signature in Layard's book, suggests that she was named for her cousin-by-marriage Abigail West (1759-1770), the wife of Holmes Hole innkeeper Isaac Daggett (1737-1805).[3]

The Bradley Church evolved from the Oakland Mission, established by Susan Clapp Bradley (1832-1908) in 1890. In 1895 she built a house on Masonic Avenue, named Oakland Hall, for her mission activities. Rev. Oscar E. Denniston, a Jamaican-born minister who had come to the Island in 1901 to work with chaplain Madison Edwards at the Seamen's Bethel

1 Charles E. Banks, *History of Martha's Vineyard* (Edgartown: Dukes County Historical Society,1911), vol. 2, Annals of Tisbury, p. 69.
2 Banks, *History,* vol. III, pp. 131,136.
3 Banks, *History,* vol. III, pp. 133-134.



Bradley Memorial Church.

in Vineyard Haven, became involved with the Oakland Mission soon after. When Susan Bradley died in 1908, Denniston became the pastor of the Oakland Mission, which was renamed Bradley Memorial Church in memory of its founder. Susan Bradley was a well-known Christian educator and missionary born in Stoughton, Massachusetts. She carried out her education activities for the American Missionary Association among African Americans after the Civil War in North Carolina. Later she worked in Boston and came to Oak Bluffs (then named Cottage City) in 1890 and married Stephen H. Bradley, who owned and leased his land to what was to become the Martha's Vineyard Camp Meeting Association.[4] Under Rev. Denniston, Bradley Memorial Church served the Island's African American community, as well as the Portuguese and Azorean immigrants who had been the focus of Bradley's work at the Oakland Mission. Susan Bradley may well have purchased the two-volume *Nineveh and its Remains*, which remained in print into the 1880s, when she established the library at Oakland Hall.

Why would a Tisbury schoolteacher and a missionary church for immigrants in Cottage City own books about an ancient empire that flourished more than 3,000 years ago and 5,600 miles away? The answer lies in the nature of the discoveries that Layard's books reported, and in the religious fervor that pervaded the Vineyard—sometimes more intense, sometimes less intense, but always present—throughout the 1800s.

4 "Susan Clapp Bradley [obituary]," *Vineyard Gazette,* 17 September 1908.



Nashki Gate at Nineveh.

Capitals of the Assyrian Empire Revealed

An English adventurer, Austin Henry Layard (1817-1894) began his excavations at the vast mound of Nimrud—23 miles south of Mosul, Iraq—in 1845 and continued for two years. He later expanded his excavations to include the great mound of Kuyunjik, part the ancient city of Nineveh, which stood on the east bank of the Tigris River, opposite the modern city of Mosul. Both Nimrud and Nineveh were once among the largest cities in the ancient world, and both in turn served as the capital of the Assyrian Empire, which lasted 1250 BCE to 612 BCE. Layard's excavations revealed the palaces of Assyrian kings and the royal library of cuneiform tablets holdings and the political and religious history of the empire.[5] Nimrud was modest in size—a city of 900 acres (1.5 square miles) surrounded by five miles of walled fortifications—but Nineveh was a metropolis of over 18,000 acres (28 square miles) protected by eight miles of massive walls with only eight gates. Nimrud became the second capital of the Assyrian Empire under Ashurnasirpal II, king from 884-859 BCE. The Assyrian Empire reached its peak in 722-705 BCE under the reign of Sargon II, stretching from the Persian Gulf to western Turkey, and through southward through Lebanon, Israel, and Egypt as far as the city of Thebes on the banks of the Nile. Sargon's son Sennacherib, who succeeded him and reigned from 705-681 BCE, moved the imperial capital to Nineveh, which he renovated and expanded for the purpose. It remained there until 612

5 Gordon Waterfield, *Layard of Nineveh* (Frederick A. Praeger, 1963), pp. 192-193.

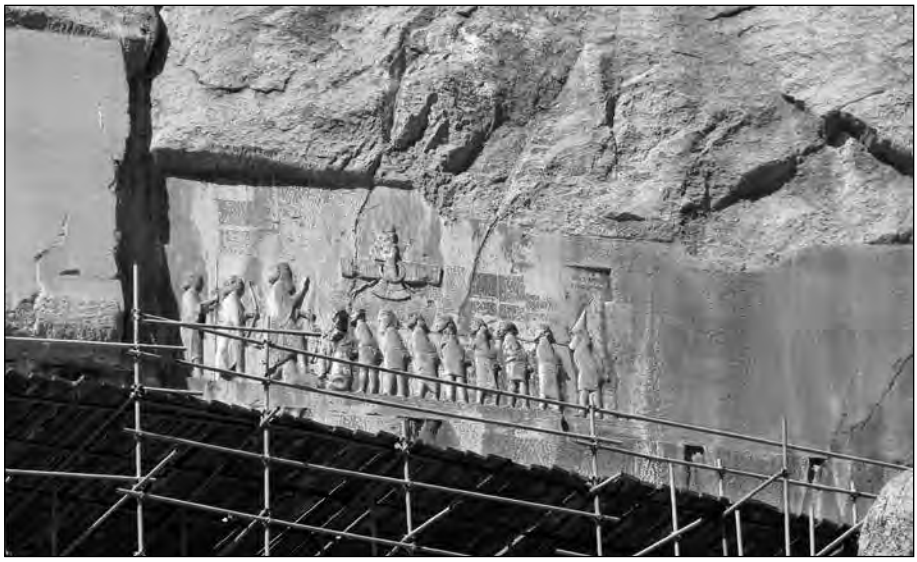


The Assyrian Empire.

BCE, when the Assyrian Empire was conquered by an alliance of opposing states led by Babylon, which ruled over its remains.

Layard benefitted from the earlier work of another English adventurer, Henry C. Rawlinson, who had deciphered the cuneiform script used by the Assyrians and so made their inscriptions readable. Rawlinson's method was similar to that used by Jean-Francois Champollion to decipher Egyptian hieroglyphics in 1822. Where Champollion used the Rosetta Stone—which contained the same text inscribed in hieroglyphics, demotic script, and Greek—to make sense of hieroglyphics, Rawlinson used the Behistun inscription, a massive carving on the side of a limestone cliff in Iran, created during the reign (522-486 BCE) of Darius I of the Persian Empire. The inscription presents the same text in three different cuneiform-script languages: Old Persian, Elamite, and the Babylonian version of Akkadian—the language of the Assyrian empire. Rawlinson, in the mid-1830s, successfully used Old Persian, which he could read, to decipher the cuneiform language of the Assyrians. Layard, and the scholars who studied the material he collected, could thus understand the meaning of their inscriptions.

Layard, like other European archaeologists of the era, shipped the artifacts he unearthed back to his home country. The haul from Nimrud and Nineveh included giant stone sculptures of human-headed winged bulls, and huge stone slabs from the walls of palaces, embellished with

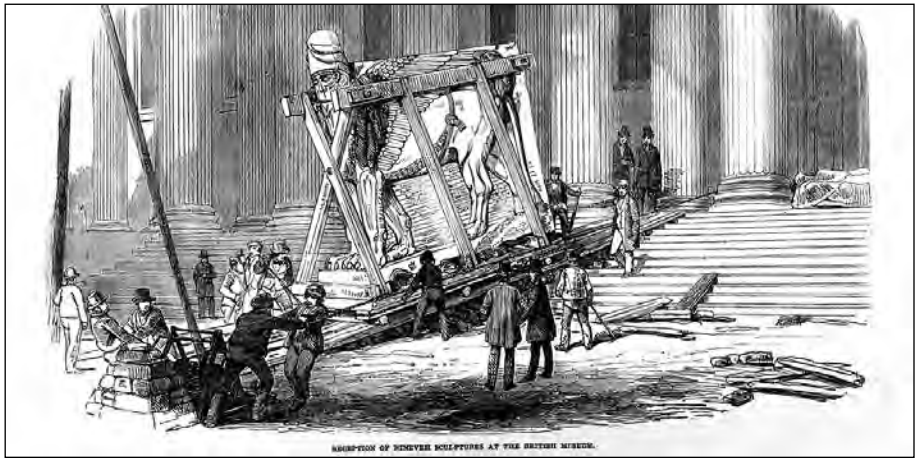


The Behistun inscription.

cuneiform writing and decorated with reliefs of hunting, battles and the portraits of the mighty kings like Sennacherib and Ashurbanipal. Sent to the British Museum in London, they became the core of its Assyrian collection, and were said to rival discoveries in Egypt. Placed on display beginning in 1847, they captivated the British public. Henry Rawlinson, who had been re-posted to Baghdad by the Foreign Office in 1851, sent additional artifacts from Nineveh to the British Museum, supplementing the collection assembled by Layard.

Large collections of artifacts from Nineveh also went to the Louvre in Paris and the Metropolitan Museum of Art in New York, the largest holder of Assyrian artifacts in North America. Over 30 museums and seminaries in the United States and Canada hold Nineveh sculptures, including the Museum of Fine Arts in Boston, the Oriental Institute in Chicago, and the museums of the University of Pennsylvania and Amherst, Dartmouth, and Bowdoin Colleges. Departments of Assyriology were founded at many universities, including Harvard and Yale, to study them.[6]

6 Gareth Brereton, ed. *I Am Ashurbanipal King of the World, King of Assyria* (Thames and Hudson, 2018); Benjamin R. Foster, "The Beginnings of Assyriology in the United States," in *Orientalism, Assyriology and the Bible*, ed. Steven W. Holloway, Hebrew Bible Monographs (2007) vol. 10, pp. 45-73; Steven W. Holloway," Nineveh Sails for the New World:" *Iraq* (2004) vol. 66: pp. 243-256; Shawn Malley, "Austen Layard and the Periodical Press: Middle Eastern Archaeology and the Excavation of Cultural Identity in Mid-Nineteenth Century Britain," *Victorian Review*, vol. 22, no. 2 (1996): pp. 152-170; John Malcolm Russell, *From Nineveh to New York: The Strange Story of the Assyrian Reliefs in the Metropolitan Museum and the Hidden Masterpiece at Canford School* (Yale University Press, 1992).



A winged bull at the British Museum.

Layard's Books Take Europe and America by Storm

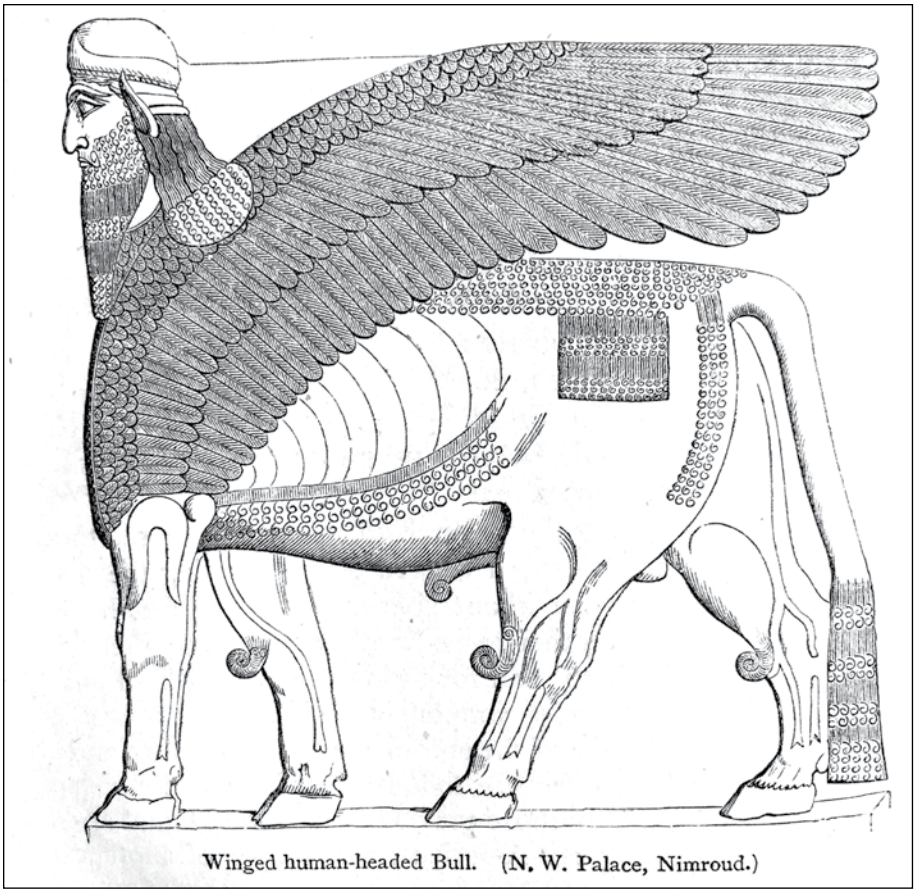
Layard lost no time in capitalizing on the public's interest in his work by publishing the results. *Nineveh and its Remains* appeared in 1849 in two volumes, one of text and the other of illustrations. *Nineveh and its Remains* received glowing reviews. Frederick Bohrer stated that "…*Nineveh and its Remains* of 1849 still ranks as the greatest bestseller in the history of its field ."[7] It sold 8,000 copies of the set in its first year and was reprinted four times. Layard followed it, before the end of 1849 was out, with a book of 100 additional plates titled *The Monuments of Nineveh from Drawings made on the Spot.* A sequel to the latter, containing 75 never-before-published plates, appeared in 1853.

Layard's *Inscriptions in the Cuneiform Character from Assyrian Monuments* came out in 1851. *A Popular Account of Discoveries at Nineveh,* an inexpensive abridged edition of *Nineveh and Its Remains* designed for sale in railway stations and similar settings, appeared in 1852 and sold 14,000 copies in *its* first year on the market, presumably to people who did not already own the more expensive two-volume edition. *Discoveries in the Ruins of Nineveh and Babylon*—Abigail Daggett's book—appeared in 1853, presenting the results of his second expedition to Mesopotamia (1849-1852).

The American editions of Layard's books—those available on the Vineyard—were published in New York City by George P. Putnam, who reprinted the original 1849 *Nineveh and Its Ruins* each year to 1851 selling 13,000 copies.[8] The 1849 edition was printed by Putnam from the origi-

7 Timothy Larsen, "Austen Henry Layard's Nineveh: The Bible and Archaeology in Victorian Britain," *Journal of Religious Studies* vol.33, no. 1 (2009): pp. 66-81, on p. 67.

8 Holloway, "Nineveh Sails for the New World," p. 249; Malley, "Austen Henry Layard and the Periodical Press," p. 155.



Layard's illustration of a winged bull.

nal plates sent by its London publisher, John Murray. His 1853 *Discoveries among the Ruins of Nineveh and Babylon* was distributed by three New York publishers with the last republication in 1875. The British publisher John Murray III published further abridged editions as late as 1882.[9]The Layard discoveries and publications stimulated a tsunami of books on the Near East. His discoveries in Nimrud, Nineveh and Babylon led to an obsession with all things Assyrian that was expressed in huge exhibits, paintings, jewelry, ceramics, and theatrical productions. Henrietta McCall says: "The evocative names of kings and queens, cities and rivers, culled from the Bible and classical authors, were relished by a public drawn to this thrilling vanished world."[10]

9 Larsen, "Austin Henry Layard's Nineveh" p. 67.

10 Henrieta McCall, "Assyrian Revival," in *I am Ashurbanipal, King of the World, King of Assyria*, edited by Gareth Brereton (London, Thames and Hudson Ltd, 2020), pp. 300-311, on p. 302.

Nineveh and its Religious Impact

The public's fascination with Layard's discoveries was went deeper, however, than curiosity about exotic ancient civilizations. The extent to which archaeological evidence confirms (or undermines) the historical narratives found in the Bible has been a subject of conversation—and often debate—since Middle Eastern became an organized enterprise. The debates continued today.[11] There are numerous references in the Assyrian and Babylonian cuneiform writing to cities, people and events mentioned in the Old Testament.

To readers intimately familiar with biblical texts, Layard's discoveries—especially the illustrations of them—not only brought those texts to life but provided evidence (to those predisposed to believe it) that the people were real and the stories were true. The Black Obelisk of Shalmaneser III (reigned 858-824 BCE), for example, was constructed in 825 BCE and discovered by Layard at Nimrud in 1846. It includes a representation of Jehu, whose slaying of the idolatrous King Ahab and his wife Jezebel, and ascension to the throne of the northern kingdom of Israel, are described in the First and Second Books of Kings.[12] Holloway notes that "Layard's publications certainly didn't supplant the family Bible in American parlours, but within a few years, nearly every American picture Bible boasted its Layard/Murray images." He further comments that



Layard's black obelisk.

11 Israel Finkelstein and Neil Asher Silberman, *The Bible Unearthed: Archaeology's New Vision of Ancient Israel and the Origin of its Sacred Texts* (The Free Press, 2001); William G. Dever, *Has Archaeology Buried the Bible?* (William B. Eerdman's Publishing Company, 2020).

12 Terence. C. Mitchell, *The Bible in the British Museum: Interpreting the Evidence* (British Museum Publications, 2004), pp. 51-54.

"…many avenues of nascent Assyriological knowledge emerged, aimed explicitly at a public hungry for biblical confirmation."[13]

Layard's book enraptured the zealous Christians of Victorian England and America because they saw his discoveries as evidence that would support their belief in biblical infallibility and inerrancy. Layard constantly cited the Bible in his book. Theorizing, for example, that the mound in which he dug, Nimrud, was a part of a greater metropolis called Nineveh, he repeatedly cited the Book of Ezekiel, and other biblical texts that mentioned the ancient city. This led the zealous—who were in the midst of defending the Bible against a style of literary criticism that began in the Enlightenment[14]—to embrace the book as definitive evidence of the Bible's veracity. Some even saw Layard's work, approvingly, as evidence of the impending End of Days. One such correspondent wrote to Layard: "You can scarcely dream of the importance which your solitary labors may have upon the understanding of the Bible's historicity." The correspondent went on to explain that the Second Coming of Christ "is to be brought about only by a knowledge of the true meaning of the Sacred Scriptures" and that "I believe that state has arrived, and this is one for the great reason for the interest I take in what you are doing . . ."[15] A British embassy friend in Constantinople, while acknowledging the appeal of Layard's work to the zealous, had a more cynical take. He urged Layard to "write a whopper with lots of plates; fish up old legends and antidotes, and if you can by any means humbug people into the belief that you have established any points in the Bible, you are a made man."[16]

Layard's use of Biblical prophecy in connection with his findings struck a chord with readers who already possessed a strong belief of the Bible's literal and inerrant truth. His actual motives, however, were just the opposite, and his actual contributions biblical apologetics were minimal. His goal was not to use his archaeological findings to demonstrate the historical accuracy of the Bible, but to use the Bible to make sense of his archaeological discoveries. This approach, and his lack of interest in corroborating the Bible archaeologically, was deeply rooted in his own religious convictions.

Layard's beliefs were heterodox. He "…had positioned himself on the

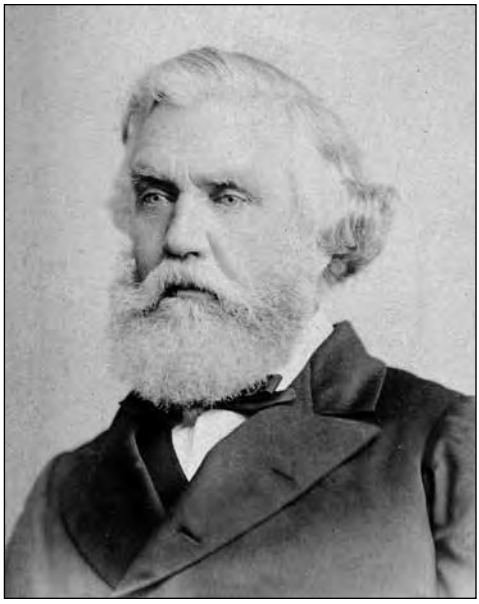
13 Steven W. Holloway, "Nineveh Sails for the New World," pp. 251, 253.

14 "Higher Criticism," as it was known, originated among German biblical scholars in the late eighteenth century, and gained popularity in Britain and America in the early nineteenth century. Its central premise—that the Bible should be treated, like any other written text, as the work of human authors influenced by the time and place in which they wrote—was embraced by liberal Protestants and despised by conservative ones, who saw it as a rejection of the Bible's divine authorship and thus its inerrancy.

15 Larsen, "Austin Henry Layard's Nineveh," p. 70.

16 Malley, "Austin Henry Layard and the Periodical Press," p. 157.

boundary line where Unitarianism crossed over into freethought"—that is, into atheism. As Larsen points out these "Freethinkers often openly scoffed at the Bible and sought actively to expose it as false." In England, he was associated with many religious and political radicals who, he wrote, "…rapidly undermined the religious opinions in which I had been brought up."[17] Evidence of Layard's heterodox predilections can be found throughout his book, particularly his interest in Chaldean Christians, referred to in the West as "Nestorians." Nestorius was Patriarch of Constantinople from 428 CE to 431 CE, when he was deposed by the Council of Ephesus for his own heterodox beliefs. The head of the Antiochene school of Christology, Nestorius emphasized the human aspect of Christ's nature more strongly than the divine. He rejected Mary as the *Theotokos* ("God-bearer") and taught that Jesus, conceived and born by conventional means, was not divine. Twenty years after Nestorius was deposed, the Council of Chalcedon (451 CE) which reaffirmed Mary as the *Theotokos* and Christ's dual identity: simultaneously fully divine and fully human. Many Christians in the East, however, rejected the conclusion of the council. Among them were the Chaldeans in Assyria who maintained, as Nestorius had, an extreme distinction between Christ's human and divine natures.


Austin Henry Layard.

Layard took interest in these people not necessarily because of their theological position, but because of his own experiences of being part of a persecuted religious minority. As a British schoolboy growing up in predominantly Catholic France and Italy, Layard was harassed for being Protestant, and developed strong anti-Roman-Catholic sentiments. Layard spoke at length in the book about how this Christian group suffered from "…the persecutions of Popish emissaries' and how their worship was superior to that of the Church of Rome."[18] These and other comments prompted similar anti-Catholic comments from British reviewers. It is also likely that Layard's sympathy for the Chaldeans came from knowing that his own Christological opinions would be considered heretical in his homeland.

17 Larsen, "Austen Layard's Nineveh," pp. 75-76.
18 Larsen, "Austin Henry Layard's Nineveh," p. 75.

When offered communion at a Chaldean worship service, Layard did not partake. When his hosts were offended, he explained to them that he did not refuse because of religious prejudice. It is reasonable to infer based on his "…radical Unitarianism, that he objected to the sacrament *per se*—whether of the Church of England or any other body."[19] If this inference is accurate, then Layard was most certainly not a Christian, as rejection of the sacrament would starkly mark him as a non-believer.

Camp Meetings and Great Awakenings

Abigail W. Daggett's religious beliefs, like those of many of her Vineyard contemporaries, were as deeply and conventionally pious as Austen H. Layard's were heterodox. Daggett and her generation were born and raised amid the Second Great Awakening (1795-1835), an era of religious revival when Methodist evangelism swept the Vineyard, bringing hundreds of Islanders to the faith and inaugurating the week-long summer "camp meetings" that would, by mid-century, draw tens of thousands of pilgrims to the Island every summer. During the Second Great Awakening camp meeting associations sprung up throughout the eastern United States spreading the word of God. The Methodists held their first camp meeting on the Vineyard at West Chop in 1827, led by circuit-riding evangelist "Reformation" John Adams. Adams spent three years (1821-1823 and 1826-1827) as a minister on the Vineyard exhorting the Islanders to convert to Methodism. His preaching was so successful that Methodism soon became the largest denomination on the Island.[20] Henry Beetle Hough says of Adams: "The minister was a flaming sword, an exhorter, a mighty shaker of the devil's kingdom, and his week of open meetings near the West Chop Lighthouse brought forty sinners into the fold and demonstrated the power of the camp meeting."[21]



"Reformation" John Adams.

19 Larsen, "Austin Henry Layard's Nineveh," p. 77.

20 Arthur R. Railton, " Setting the Stage for the Camp Meeting," *Dukes County Intelligencer*, vol. 26, no. 4 (May 1985):139-154; Arthur R. Railton, "The Hallucinations of Rev. John Adams," *Dukes County Intelligencer*, vol. 32, no. 3 (February 1991): pp. 21-41.

21 Hough, *Martha's Vineyard Summer Resort, 1835-1935* (Tuttle Publishing Co., 1936), p. 35.



Worshipers under the canvas Tabernacle.

Camp meetings would, in time, transform the Island in ways that Adams could scarcely have imagined. In 1835 Vineyarders established the Martha's Vineyard Camp Meeting Association, and laid out a campground in what was then northern Edgartown on a 34-acre tract of woodland they called Wesleyan Grove. This site played host to annual camp meetings held each August, drawing steadily increasing numbers of attendees. In 1842 there were 1,189, in 1851 between 3,500 and 4,000 and by 1858, 12,000 celebrants flooded into the area.[22] Temporary shops and service businesses open on the edges of the Campground each summer and beginning in 1870 a giant canvas tent was erected each summer to protect worshipers from the elements.[23]

The Baptists—who, like the Methodists, had seen their numbers swell during the Second Great Awakening—established their own summer camp meeting in a nearby wooded area known as Vineyard Highlands in

22 Chris Stoddard, *A Centennial History of Cottage City* (1987), pp. 27-42; Ellen Weiss, *City in the Woods: The Life and Design of an American Camp Meeting on Martha's Vineyard* (1987), pp. 3, 24-38.

23 Hough, *Summer Resort,* pp. 82-83.

1875. In place of the Methodists' massive canvas tent, they erected an octagonal, open-sided wooden one over their worship area in 1878, inspiring the Methodists to commission their own Tabernacle—similar in design, but built of wrought iron—the following year.[24] The tents that sheltered Methodist worshippers in the Antebellum era—canvas roofs and walls over wood-platform floors—gave way, after the Civil War, to elaborately decorated wooden cottages erected on the old tent sites. Baptist visitors commissioned similar cottages in Vineyard Highlands, and in 1880 the two settlements were incorporated (along with other villages in northern Edgartown) as the newly independent town of Cottage City. The Third Great Awakening (1857-1920) was well underway by then, and both camp meetings continued to grow and prosper.

The Methodist and Baptist camp meetings, as Henry Beetle Hough noted, created the foundations of Martha's Vineyard's tourist economy, and set the stage for its emergence as a summer resort. Devout families from off-Island, Methodist and Baptist alike, returned to their cottages summer after summer, arriving before Camp Meeting Week and remaining after it, to socialize and enjoy the relaxing surroundings. Secular developers, sensing opportunity, bought up farmland and divided into lots for summer homes. The first of those developments, Oak Bluffs, eventually (in 1907) lent its name to the entire town, by then one of the most famous summer resorts in the Northeast.

Over the course of the late-nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, the Island's expanding resort economy eventually drew in Edgartown, Vineyard Haven, and the up-Island towns of West Tisbury, Chilmark, and Gay Head (now Aquinnah). The impact of the Second and Third Great Awakenings, however, touched them just as deeply and much sooner. Methodist and Baptist congregations formed, and meetinghouses were built to accommodate them, across the Island. They grew at the expense of the Puritan (later Congregational) churches that had dominated religious life on the Island since the arrival of the first English colonizers in the 1640s and became the driving force behind local abolitionism and temperance movements. Susan Clapp Bradley's Oakland Mission—and the Bradley Memorial Church into which it evolved—were Baptist enterprises, created to do God's work on Earth by improving the lives of those (particularly immigrants and people of color) on the margins of the booming resort economy.

Among those caught up in the religious fervor of the mid-nineteenth century was Abigail's relative William Daggett (1773-1858): a master mariner, pioneering abolitionist and a major figure in the Methodist Church in Holmes Hole (now Vineyard Haven).[25] His wife, Jane Daggett (born

24 Hough, *Summer Resort,* pp. 146-152.

25 Banks, *History*, vol. III, pp. 139-140.

1778), was the daughter of Isaac Daggett and Abigail West—Abigail West Daggett's cousin-by-marriage and the source of her middle name.[26] William and Jane Daggett donated the pastureland in downtown Holmes Hole on which the village's first Methodist Church was established in 1833, leaving what had been a multi-denominational meetinghouse on Main Street for the exclusive use of the Baptists. The Baptists built a new and larger structure on Main Street in 1837, and in 1845 a new Methodist Church was erected across the street from the old one, which the congregation had already outgrown.[27] The new church (which burned in 1923 and was replaced by the current stone church) faces onto William Street—named, appropriately, for Capt. William Daggett.



Vineyard Haven Methodist Church (1845-1923).

Similar stories unfolded in other Island towns. The Methodists of Edgartown built a meetinghouse in 1822, quickly outgrew it, and built a larger one on Main Street (now the Town Hall) in 1827. When they outgrew the second, they built a third across the street, opened in 1843 and now called the Old Whaling Church. Edgartown's first Methodist meetinghouse was moved to Middle Road in Chilmark, where it served the local congregation until they, too, outgrew it and built a larger one. The Baptists, meanwhile, were erecting meetinghouses of their own: one on what is now School Street in Edgartown, one in Eastville (now part of Oak Bluffs), and two in West Tisbury. These structures—like the campgrounds and tabernacles of Cottage City—were the visible symbols of the Great Awakening, but so too was the presence of Austen Layard's books in Island homes, churches, libraries. Vineyarders like Abigail West Daggett might never have the opportunity to see, first-hand, the lands of the Old Testament stories they knew so well, but Layard's books brought them to vivid life.

26 Banks, *History*, vol. III, pp. 134-139.

27 Banks, *History*, vol. II, Annals of Tisbury, pp. 46-47. The Baptist meetinghouse at the corner of Spring and Main Streets was destroyed in the Great Fire of 1883 and replaced two years later by the current Baptist Church at the corner of Spring and William.

Talking to Norman Bridwell

oral history interviews by Linsey Lee
excerpted & introduced by Bonnie Stacy

Linsey Lee has collected oral histories on the Island for more than 30 years, most of that time as oral history curator of the Martha's Vineyard Museum. This activity has resulted in a collection of 1,400 interviews with 800 people. Every one of these interviews presents a unique view of this place and together they capture an irreplaceable picture of the Vineyard and its people.

In 2013 and 2014, Linsey visited Norman Bridwell (1928-2014) in his Edgartown home and over several hours recorded him talking about his home, his art and his beloved creation: Clifford, the Big Red Dog. Here are some excerpts from those interviews:

On his interest in art:

My father would bring home order forms from the shop [the metal foundry where he worked] that had been used on one side and I used the other side as drawing paper.

I couldn't do anything else. Sometimes kids say, "Well, what else would you do to make a living?" And I'd say, "I can't nail boards together; I'm terrible. A shop teacher took my tools away from me and told me to sit in the corner and draw. He was afraid I was going to hurt myself." But that's all I can do. Couldn't play music. Couldn't nail things together. Terrible at math. I was kind of a clown.

I had my drawing table, which was my world. And if I had a place to sit down and draw I was pretty much at home.

On childhood pets:

We had one cat when I was growing up and about four dogs, not all at the same time. One at a time. And they were just any dog that wandered down the street and seemed to be homeless—that was our dog. We always had used pets that somebody else had owned and they'd either become lost or been abandoned. I loved the dogs. They were usually kind of dopey little dogs. That's maybe why I always wanted a big dog.

On the Martha's Vineyard house:

We came here on our honeymoon, 55 years ago. And then came back about eight years later to show the children the place. And saw a sign on a lot and my wife said, "Wouldn't it be nice to own a little house here?" And I think it was about the next year we came up and looked at houses, and we really couldn't afford the ones that were so colorful, downtown.... But this place was newly renovated by the owner who wanted to leave and go to Florida. And we just happened to stumble onto it and bought it.

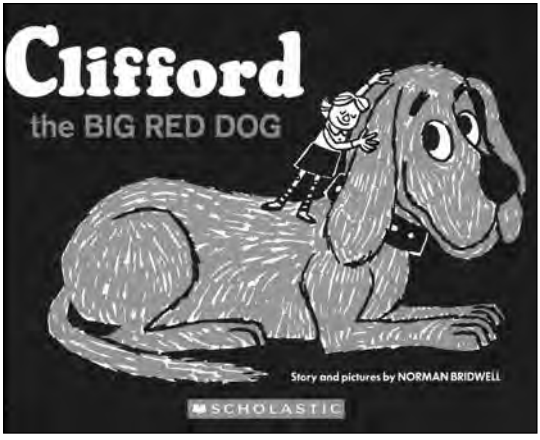
We looked at houses and we couldn't afford the captain's house that we thought was so charming... So Bob Carroll showed us this place. He said, "Well, it's not on the water." I said, "Well, that doesn't matter so much. We can walk to the water." And so the house was available and we didn't have a lot of money. We could afford it at the time. And so we bought it and my friends in New York said, "Oh, did you go in the basement? Did you see what the plumbing looked like? Hey, how about the foundation? Did you check that?" I said, "No, I just walked in the house, walked through, out the back door, and I called my wife, and said 'we've got a house'." And she agreed. She came to walk through one time. I said, "Okay, we'll buy it."

We've had experiences with people photographing us. And one photographer came and looked around and said, "Well, it's not much of a house." So he got on the phone to Boston, and said, "It's not a showplace." So another time a woman who was working for a magazine took me down—"We're not going to photograph this. We'll go down to Water Street, and you'll stand in front of the house down there." So we stood in front of one of the Captain's houses and I pretended it was my house. I thought, well, that's not really … she was, "Well, it'll make a better story," said: "This house doesn't look like much." I said, "Okay, fine."

On the origin of Clifford:

Well, I was working, as I said, in New York, doing films and slides and things like that. And one year was a very bad year. There wasn't a lot of work, and I was out of work and looking. And Norma said, "Well, you always wanted to do children's books. Why don't you do some samples of children's books?" So I made about eight or ten paintings of what I thought would be maybe something that could be used in children's books. And I took them around and was rejected everywhere. Nobody was the least bit interested. And one editor at Harper Row, a young lady, said, "Well, you're not very good. Your art's not that good. Why don't you try writing a story and if they buy the story, then you can do the art." And she pointed to one of my sample paintings, a little girl with a big red dog. He was towering over her head, and she was holding her hand out to see if the rain had stopped—that kind

of thing. And so I had nothing else to do—I went home and in three days' time I made up this story about this dog named Clifford. Well, I was going to call him Tiny but my wife talked me out of that. She said, "Oh, name him something else—Clifford." So, okay, Clifford—it didn't matter. Nobody's going to see this book. And we made up a little book, with actual sketches and cover and everything, and took it to one place and left it at the desk. And a lady who worked there who came in to check what they call the "slush pile" of unsolicited work, she saw it and she knew this publisher would never take it. But she also worked for Scholastic doing the same thing. She put it in her purse and took it to Scholastic and they bought it. And I got this phone call. I'm out of work for about a month. My mother's visiting from Indiana. It was hot and the baby's been crying all night. And this woman says, "I have this book here called *Clifford, the Big Red Dog.* We'd like to publish it. Would you be interested?" My voice—I almost strangulated, you know? I said, "Yes, yes!" So that was the beginning.



The first Clifford book (1963).

On the Way Clifford Looks:

It was just kind of a daydream I had from being a child. I read that there were dogs in Europe that could pull carts, and I thought, "Wouldn't it be nice to have a dog that big that you could ride on, or have a little cart attached to him?" And of course I never got it, so I thought about it and he was there in my mind, I guess. And I really have no idea—somebody wrote to me and said, "How did you arrive at the properties of this dog? What process did you go through?" And I said, "There's no process. He just came to me. It seemed like a natural thing."

On how Clifford became a series:

[the second book was] *Clifford Gets a Job.* He's eating too much dog food and he's got to be on his way. So he goes through a variety of attempts at finding a job. And then I did another one, and I said to the editor, "If I have any more ideas, can I bring them to you?" And she said, "Well, we're not running the Norman Bridwell Book Club. But if you have an idea, yes, submit it." And then they re-issued the Clifford book, the original, and it sold much better the second time than it did the first. So she called me up and said, "I've changed my mind. We are running the Norman Bridwell Book Club."

On Clifford's changes over time:

I looked at the first art as I began to do more books. And I thought, "Well, I want to improve him." I didn't like—he was all kind of angular and jagged. I started to round him off. I started to make his head a little bit bigger, like he really had a brain. And I just changed him to what I thought was a better-looking dog, in a matter of time, you know.

I've never—only in one book did I ever have a computer, because I didn't think they were going to last. (laughs) I never realized when they first started how—well, for one thing, if you put something electronic in a book, the field is changing so quickly that by the time that book is edited and published, they'll have moved on to some other way of communicating. Like I thought recently, "Well, I might have Clifford or Emily with an IPad, or a small computer. But then other things come along that supersede that. And then you think, the kid looks at it—I had one child at a reading that I did. I had Clifford the puppy riding on a turntable. Like a record turntable. And the child said, "What's that?" I never thought that children today don't know what a record turntable is, what it looks like. Because everything is done, delivered musically by some other means. So I've kind of slipped up on the computer age.

On Clifford's personality:

His personality is always loyal to his owner, unselfish. He just is the kind of dog who tries to do his best, and because of his size sometimes things go wrong, so he's always forgiven. Emily's never really angry with him. She always comes back to him, and he comes back to her. And he just is—I don't know. I didn't really think it out. But he's just the kind of dog I think you'd like to have. And that's it.

Clifford's main purpose in life is to get into trouble and then get out of it.

On Clifford as a puppy:

Oh, the little puppy. I did about four books about him growing up. And I began to get letters from children saying, "Well, where did he come from? Were his mother and father big dogs? Was he a big puppy?" And I thought, "Well, let's make him small. Make him more to overcome." So I did a book called *Clifford, the Small Red Puppy* where he was very tiny, sickly. The man that gave him to Emily said, "Well, you can take him, but he's not going to live very long," something like that. "He's a runt," and she loved him, so she took him anyway. And she said to him, "Clifford, I love you. Please grow." And he grew. Overnight he went up to a big dog. And children seemed to accept this. Well, I did that book and then they kept saying, "Well, now let's have Clifford's first birthday, Clifford's first Christmas." I said, "But he grew

up overnight." "Never mind, the children won't notice." So we did a series of Clifford's first Valentine's, Christmas, that kind of thing.

On the PBS Kids television show that ran between 2000 and 2003:

I sent them photographs. I took photographs of the Island. It wasn't my idea to have him based on Martha's Vineyard...it's called Birdwell Island...I could hear a child talking to his mother on the way over on the ferry, and she's saying, "No, we're not going to Birdwell Island." That was somebody's idea to base him on a place like Martha's Vineyard. And so I approved the first six scripts. And I approved the art that they were going to use. And they took it from there. And I think they did a good job.

I took some photographs around the Island because they wanted to make Clifford live on Martha's Vineyard. I'd always avoided that because not every child is familiar with Martha's Vineyard, and I wanted it always to be he lived in some place in the USA, but never said where. So they decided that they would make it Birdwell Island, because so many people mispronounced my name as "Birdwell." And I said, "Okay, well, you're the writers. I'll go along with it." And so I sent them photographs and I approved the animation sketches, and from there on I stayed out of it because I don't really know writing for television. And I think they did a good job.

On the wide reach and impact of the Clifford books:

They were in France, Germany, Sweden, Italy, Brazil, Greece—oh, boy. Where else?...

Some Christian organization had books printed in Chinese to distribute. Like missionary work. I don't know why they used Clifford, … Yes, well he's a good example, yes. And I get letters—a letter from Tasmania, letter from Siberia. And sometimes Singapore. So he gets around.

I think because the books are very simple—you know, they're no great literature. They're just enjoyable stories, I hope, that a child can have a few minutes a day reading and maybe getting a laugh or two. I've known—I've had people say, "Well, my child, we thought he would never read until somebody gave him a Clifford book. And he saw the words under the pictures and he thought the pictures were funny and he wanted to know what was going on, so he learned to read." I had a young man at a thing I did in New York who came up to me and he said, "You know, I moved here from Hong Kong and I was going to school, and I didn't speak any English. I didn't read English. And a friend of mine… I was determined I was not going to learn English. And a friend of mine had a book about Clifford. I looked at the pictures and I thought, 'Well, I wonder what that's about.' So I started to teach myself to read with your Clifford books." … And he said,

"I liked the art so much that I decided I would be a graphic designer. And today I have my own graphic design studio." I thought, "Well, isn't that marvelous." Because I never thought much of the art. I always thought the art was pretty crude. But he got something out of it.

On the process of making a Clifford book:

Well, thinking up the idea can take who knows how long. Sometimes three months, only to have it rejected. Go back and try again. But once it's accepted, maybe after three or four months of stirring around in my brain, I put it down on paper. I do an actual little dummy that works like the real book, so they see what—oh I'm reading this and then maybe I get a surprise when I turn the page.

I do sketches, pencil drawings, and I type or I used to type the text. And tape it underneath. And then I send it to the editor. And she'll make changes. She'll say, "Oh, this part doesn't work. Take that out. Think of something else." And we do that. We tinker around with it. And then it comes back to me and I take—if it's accepted, I take the book apart and I take those pencil sketches and I put them under white vellum paper I can see through. And I take a black ball point pen which I don't have with me anymore, and I do a very careful ink drawing for every page. Now, my part of doing the art would probably take about three weeks of doing the drawings, just plain black line work on white paper. These are photocopied and printed on watercolor paper, and a colorist—I get a little tissue with colored pencils shading where I want, which they sometimes pay attention to, sometimes not—but then another artist then takes about six weeks to do the paintings for the color in the book. And printing plates are made from those, and a printing plate is made from my black line work, and then in the press they're printed and overprinted with black line. So it takes about maybe six months before the book actually appears.

When you successfully make up a story line, when you successfully tack together a series of events that fits into the format after some chopping and sorting around, and you wind up with a book that you think will make a child laugh. That's the best feeling. Then comes the hard work of doing the drawings, the finish drawings and getting it to the printer, or the publisher. So the creative process is the most agonizing but the most satisfying. When it works.

On his other books:

Zany Zoo was about a boy changing a zoo. There was Kangaroo Stew, about two children trying to make stew out of a kangaroo. And there

was How to Care for Your Monster I did for a boy who had outgrown Clifford and wanted an older book, so I did a book about what it would be like to have a movie monster as a friend. The *Witch* books—there are five of those. Let's see—what else? *The Big Water Fight*—my son came home dripping wet from school—some kid had doused him with a squirt gun. And he was filling a bucket, and he was going to hit the kid as he came by, splash him. So I did a book called *The Big Water Fight*. Kind of a cute idea. And there was something called *My Pet the Rock*, another of my son's ideas.

I had a boy—his first letter was just remarkable. Misspelled words, but the thoughts that he put into it were just, I thought, marvelous So I wrote back to him. I usually try to write back to every child. Sometimes I can't do the whole class, but after I sent a letter back to him, his mother wrote and said, "You don't know what you've done for my son. He took your letter to school. He has a slight stutter and children make fun of him. And he took your letter and he became a star. People said, 'Oh, you know Mr. Bridwell!'" And so this boy continued to write. We still correspond, and I did a book for him called *How to Care for Your Monster*. He wrote one time and said, "I'm too old for Clifford now." So I did a book taking all the old Frankenstein, werewolf, mummy, and did a book about what do you do if you actually own one of these for a pet? Or for a live-in friend? And I was talking to him recently—he lives in Montana now—and I said, "Eddie I'd like to send you some art from the Monster book that I did and dedicated to you." And he said, "Well, you realize I'm 65 years old." I said, "Oh! My goodness—you've grown up!"

On *The Witch Next Door*:

My wife had heard Margaret Hamilton, the actress, interviewed on PBS, and she was a very gentle person. She was a kindergarten teacher before she was an actress. And she hated the idea that she was always going to be remembered as the Wicked Witch of the West. So I thought, "Well, let's do a story about a witch that is not wicked. She does good things for kids." …I sat down and I very quickly put down, overnight, the sketches for *The Witch Next Door*, what it would be like, and I have a neighbor who flies on a broom and does all the witchy things.

… I found out that it was being used in some, I guess, Unitarian Sunday Schools as teaching acceptance of other people whose beliefs are not like yours. But on the other hand, I got these letters saying, "Well, you're encouraging the occult. You're encouraging witchcraft." And I'm thinking—oh, what kind of a mind?

On getting mail:

I had a lady who helped me—I would give her the answers to questions, and she'd type up the letters, because my handwriting is so erratic. And unfortunately she passed away a few months ago. And so I had to go back to—sometimes I will take all the letters that are of a class, and I'll write on each letter, "Yes"—so answer the question and then write my name. I send them back. And in that way the parent can see what their child did, and also they get the autograph. And I've resorted to that…

I try, because I heard sometime before I was even doing books, I heard a children's author being interviewed and they said, "What am I supposed to do? I've got all these letters from children, and they expect an answer. I'm not in the business of writing letters. I write books!" And I thought, "Well, that's really kind of dumb, because these kids are giving you a good living." And so I always try as much as I am capable, to answer all mail. And I've had some heartbreaking or very moving experiences—like a little girl who I wrote to for about eight years, over a period of time, back and forth. Big Clifford fan. She'd write and tell me how she was doing. She was always going into the hospital for observation, for an operation, and always cheerful, always sunny. And then just a short time ago I got an email from her parents saying that she died. And it really hit me hard, because she was such a cheerful … never expressed any doubt, you know? Cheerful young girl about 14 when she passed away. And I have friends like that—little kids.

Maybe you're not going to make them more intelligent, or make their lives change in any way, but you can relieve the tension of the day. I had teachers write after the Twin Towers, 9-11, saying—this was a couple of months later. They said, "School was all broken up about that, but we had a serious session of Clifford reading to help them escape from that feeling, and make them feel better, less tense." And I felt great!

On the message:

I asked my editor after about two or three books, I said, "I should be putting a message in here." And she said, "No, you're not a message person." She said, "You do something that's fun to read, make them laugh, and they'll move on to the message books a little bit later, but it's not you. Just entertain." So I've never thought about putting messages in. I just kind of do—seems obvious.

…And forgiveness, forgiveness. Always …

If there's a message there, it's kind of unconscious on my part. I just do

the kind of dog I think everybody would like to have, and if he gets into situations where he teaches a lesson, that's great. But I never planned it that way. It's the teachers that have made him that kind of personality, and it amazes me what they can do in a teaching way with Clifford. I've seen so many variations on these themes.

But in a way they're just a pleasant, safe place for a child to go where there isn't violence, there isn't any meanness, I hope. Okay, say they're dull, say they're dumb, but children love them.

On book tours:

I visited a lot of schools, yes. And I did enjoy them. You'd get some marvelous reaction from kids. I remember being in a school in Florida about the time of an election. And all this radio blah-blah, "vote here, vote there" and the kids were leaving. The teacher said, "Would you shake their hands?" And I'm shaking their hands and I said, "I feel like I'm running for election." And this little boy, about seven years old who just shook my hand, turns and says, "Well, you're not getting my vote." I said to the teacher, "This kid is going to go places." But I enjoyed it because there were all these experiences where you found that you changed a child's life in some way. I was doing a book-signing for Laura Bush's reading initiative down in Washington about four or five years ago. And we had a really long line, the longest line of any of the authors. And the word was, "Don't talk to them. Don't make … just every book comes, you put it down, you sign it, send them on their way." And this one man comes up and he's got a boy about maybe 10 years old standing there. And the boy's kind of looking off in the distance, uninvolved. The man says, "I'm not supposed to talk to you, but I'm going to do it anyway." He says, "My son is autistic and we never got a reaction from anything except the first time we showed him a Clifford book. He looked at it and he said, "red dog." And we were so thrilled—I'm crying, the man's crying, the lady there from Scholastic is crying, and so we chatted for a while. I said, "You know, you don't know what this means to me, that you reach somebody. Something about the caller reaches through a barrier and touches somebody." And again, I didn't plan that, it just happened. Just works. It broke me up.

On aging:

I would buy books and they sound interesting, but I'd bring them home and I would read about maybe three paragraphs and then I would just lose interest and it's difficult because there's so much I'd like to know, so much I'd like to read. They say you have the audio books, but I hate those earphones…

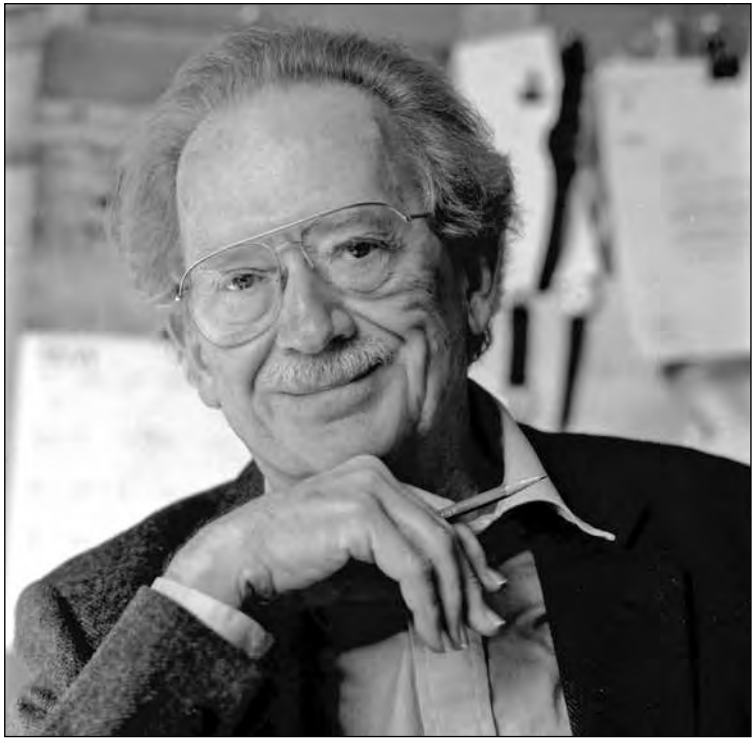
I'll try to hang on until fall. We keep trying to live through certain dates. I lived through my granddaughter's graduation from Concord Academy—that was a goal. We made that. I don't know what the next one is. The little ones are so far from graduating from anything. I probably won't do that, but I enjoy the days.

On being content with his work:

I used to think, you know, I would look at books that had beautiful artwork, and I'd say, "Oh, I wish I could do that." And my editor said, "Well, that's not you. This is what you do—be glad you can do that." And I'd always say, "Oh, so-and-so's book has such lovely artwork, but I can't do that. It just isn't me. I don't think I would—you know, I can't change. I'm stuck with what I've got.

On the difference between Clifford and Norman Bridwell:

He's not me. People say, "Oh, well, he's nice like you." I say, well, as I said before, I'm not all that nice. I just try to avoid trouble, is all.



Norman Bridwell at home. Portrait by Mark Alan Lovewell.

from the Executive Director

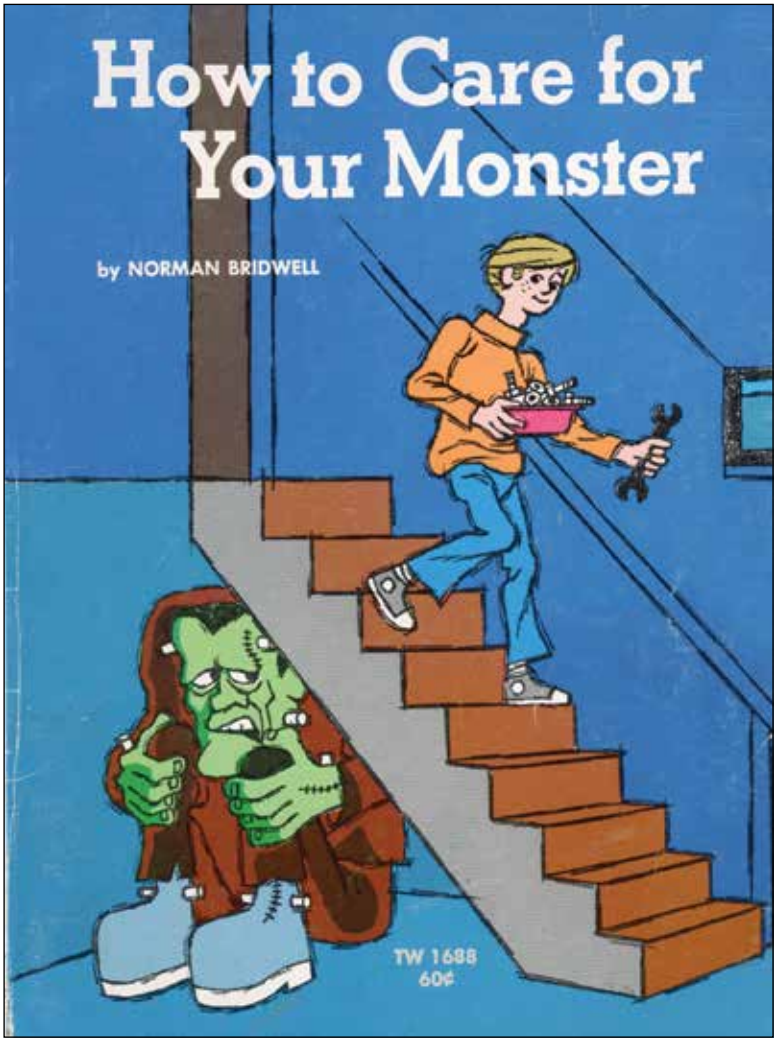
From a Place of Gratitude

In this season of Thanksgiving, even with its problematic myth about a friendly cross-cultural harvest celebration, it is worth dwelling in a place of gratitude. Gratitude, which Cicero called the greatest of and parent to all the other virtues, is indeed very much on our hearts and minds here at the Martha's Vineyard Museum.

As we celebrated the 100th anniversary of our founding this past summer, we were full of gratitude for our founders, a dedicated band of Islanders, many of them librarians, who were determined to preserve and occasionally publish historic matters related to the Vineyard and its neighboring islands. In 1923 the Dukes County Historical Society was led by Marshall Shepard, William Rotch, Ulysses Mayhew, and Francis Foster. That year, they grew the organization from 27 members at its founding to 131 members who would gather occasionally in libraries and living rooms to hear speakers discuss whaling, the colonial period, the Revolutionary War, and interesting archeological finds from around the Island. Though their focus was narrow, we celebrate their foresight, as they planted the seeds for what would eventually become the Martha's Vineyard Museum of today.

In the 100 years since our founding, we continue to be grateful for the tens of thousands of supporters, members, visitors, and donors who make our work possible. We are grateful that you share our vision for the Museum's potential, that you push us to think more broadly, and that you inspire us to continue expanding the circle of stories told through exhibitions and programs so that eventually, no one in our community is left out.

— Heather L. Seger



Though published by Scholastic Books, like the *Clifford the Big Red Dog* series, *How to Care for Your Monster* (1970) was intended for older elementary-school-age readers. It draws its visual cues from the iconic monsters featured in Universal Studios' horror films of the 1930s—Frankenstein's creature, Dracula, the Mummy, and the Wolfman—but recasts them as gently comic figures. This transformation of the horror icons, which began with Bobby Pickett's 1962 novelty song "Monster Mash," reached its peak in the early 1970s, when Bridwell's book appeared alongside CBS' Saturday-morning cartoon *Groovie Ghoulies* (1970-1972) and General Mills' monster-themed breakfast cereals "Count Chocula" and "Frankenberry," which debuted in March 1971. The young teenaged hero of *How to Care for Your Monster* is said to be modeled on Bridwell's son Tim.

Martha's Vineyard Museum
151 Lagoon Pond Road
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Unicorn headliners in the summer of 1964: (L to R) Reverend Gary Davis, Bonnie Dobson, Dave Van Ronk, The Kentucky Colonels, Jesse Fuller.